

X-Ray Calc 3

User Manual

Version 9

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Penkov, O. V., Li, M., Mikki, S., Devizenko, A. & Kopylets, I. (2024). *J. Appl. Cryst.* **57**, 555–566.

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1 Introduction

What X-Ray Calc 3 does, the calculation method, and the reference publication

X-Ray Calc 3 (XRC3) is an open-source software package for simulating X-ray reflectivity (XRR) and solving the inverse problem of reconstructing film structures from measured XRR curves. It is designed for researchers working with X-ray optics, synchrotron radiation, and thin-film coatings.

The software employs Parratt's exact recursive method based on the Fresnel equations to calculate XRR and incorporates specialized tools for modeling periodic multilayer structures (PMMs). Refractive indices of materials are computed using the Henke tables of atomic scattering factors (Henke *et al.*, 1993). The computational algorithm has been validated against the *IMD* software (Windt, 1998), with accumulated variances consistently below 0.5%.

The application allows you to:

- Build multilayer structural models composed of stacks and individual layers
- Calculate theoretical X-ray reflectivity curves as a function of incidence angle (θ) or wavelength (λ)
- Load experimental reflectivity data and compare it with theoretical predictions
- Automatically fit model parameters to experimental data using the Shake LFPSO (Lévy Flight Particle Swarm Optimization) algorithm
- Visualize results through interactive charts with logarithmic/linear scaling
- Define parameter profiles (polynomial, exponential, tabulated) across periodic structures
- Manage materials via the built-in Henke atomic form factor database

Reference: Penkov, O. V., Li, M., Mikki, S., Devizenko, A. & Kopylets, I. (2024). *X-Ray Calc 3: improved software for simulation and inverse problem solving for X-ray reflectivity*. J. Appl. Cryst. **57**, 555–566.
<https://doi.org/10.1107/S1600576724001031>

See Also

- [Quick Start](#)
- [Fitting \(Optimization\)](#)
- [Source Code & Git](#)

2 Quick Start

A hands-on tour: open a demo project, build a model from scratch, calculate and export

This section provides a hands-on introduction to X-Ray Calc 3. The distribution includes several demonstration projects in the **Examples** folder — open one to explore the interface before building your own models.

Exploring the Demo Projects

1. Click  **Open** and navigate to the **Examples** folder.
2. Select a project file (`.xrcx`).
3. Go to the **Computation** tab and click **Run** (or press **F5**). You can also use **Calc All** (**F12**) to calculate all models at once.

Navigating the Interface

- **Double-click a model name** in the Project Items list to open its Properties dialog (name, color, description). The same dialog is available from the right-click context menu.
- **Double-click a layer** to open the Layer Properties dialog, where you can change material, thickness, roughness, and density.
- **Double-click a stack header** to open the Stack Properties dialog, where you can rename the stack and change the number of periods.
- Use the **Stack** and **Layer** toolbar panels to add, insert, or delete structural elements.

Creating a Model from Scratch

1. Create a new project (**File > New Project**).
2. Select **Model 1** in the project tree.
3. Add a stack: **Structure > Add Stack** (or use the toolbar). In the dialog, set the stack name (e.g., “Main”) and the number of periods (default: 1 for non-periodic structures).
4. Select the stack by clicking its title in the structure panel.
5. Add layers: click  **Add Layer** (or **Structure > Add Layer**). Fill in the material (click “...” to select from the Materials Database), thickness, roughness, and density. Repeat for each layer.
6. Calculate the reflectivity: press **F5** (or **Calc > Calculate**).

Calculation Settings

- **Mode:** Reflectivity can be calculated as a function of grazing angle or wavelength.
- **Polarization:** Use **s-polarization** for hard X-rays at low grazing angles (below 20°) — this is significantly faster. Use **sp-polarization** for larger angles or softer radiation.
- **Number of points (N):** Controls calculation precision. Calculation time scales linearly with N.
- **Angle range:** Set with θ_1 and θ_2 . Check **2 θ** for θ -2 θ geometry. **d θ** sets the instrumental beam divergence.
- **Scale:** Toggle between **Linear** and **Log** scale using the toolbar button. Set a **background level** if needed.

- **Legend:** Click items in the chart legend to toggle curve visibility.
-

Exporting Results

- The **Export** button on the Result panel saves the calculated curve to an ASCII file or copies it to the clipboard.
- The **Save** button on the Plot panel saves the chart as a bitmap image.

See Also

- [Defining a Model](#)
- [Calculation](#)
- [Illustrative Examples](#)

3 Installation & First Launch

System requirements, the working directory, portable mode, and file association

System Requirements

- Windows 10 or later (64-bit recommended)
- Minimum 4 GB RAM (8 GB recommended for large models)
- Multi-core CPU recommended for parallel computation

Data Storage

On first launch, X-Ray Calc 3 creates a working directory:

- **Default location:** %APPDATA%\X-RayCalc3\
- **Portable mode:** If a file named uselocaldata exists in the application folder, all data is stored locally next to the executable.

The working directory contains:

FILE / FOLDER	PURPOSE
xrc3.ini	Application settings
Henke/	Atomic form factor tables
Backup/	Auto-save and backup projects
Output/	Fitting results (when auto-save is enabled)
Benchmark/	Benchmark model files
Jobs/	Batch job definitions

File Association

To associate .xrcx project files with X-Ray Calc 3, go to **File > Settings > Paths and Files** and click **Register file associations (xrcx)**.

See Also

- [Application Settings > Paths and Files](#)
- [File Formats](#)
- [Troubleshooting](#)

4 Application Overview

Main window layout, the three columns, status bar, and the menu bar

Main Window Layout

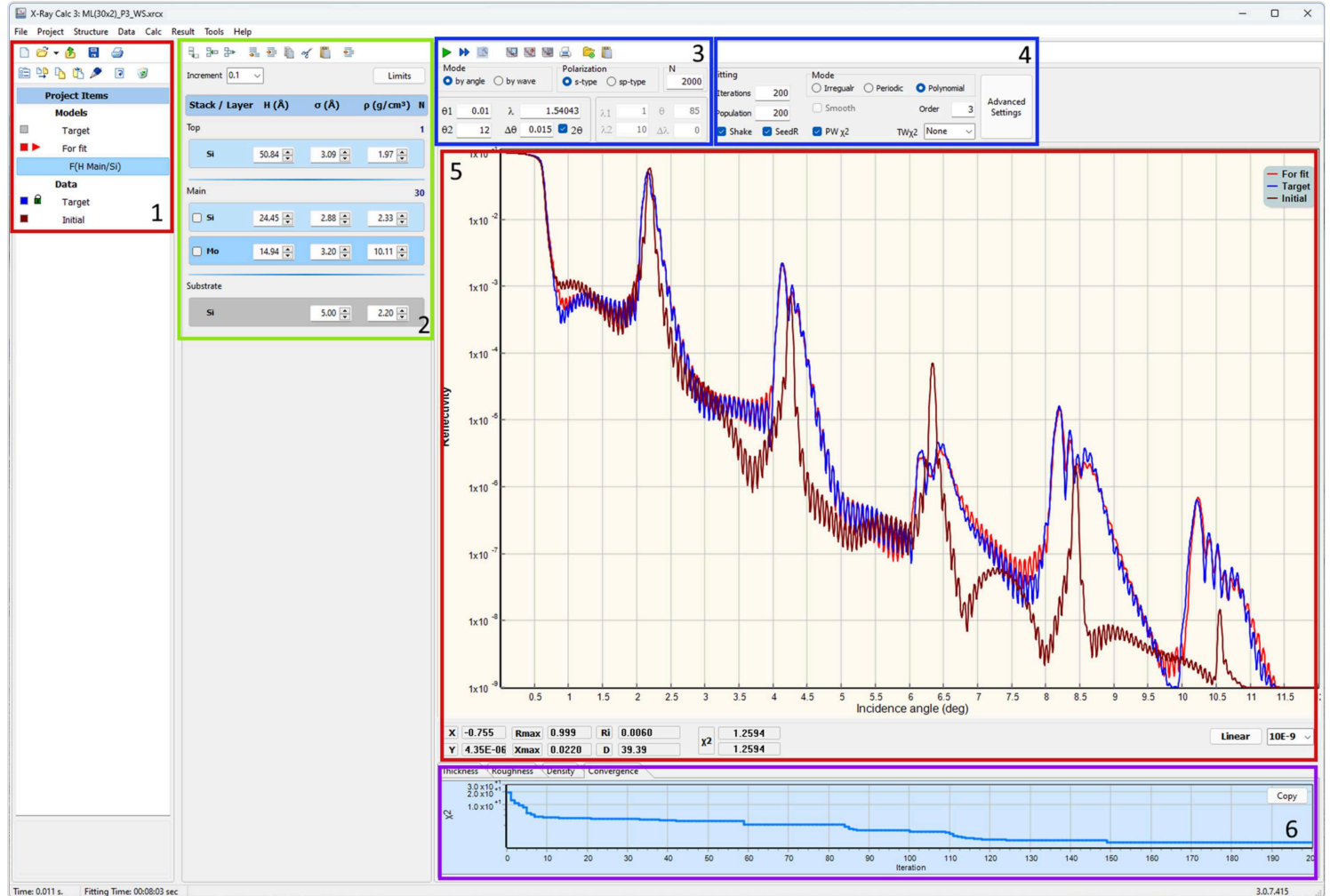


Figure 1. Screenshot of the XRC3 GUI. (1) Project tree. (2) Structure panel. (3) XRR calculation parameters. (4) Fitting parameters. (5) XRR curves. (6) Distributions / Convergence panel. (From Penkov et al., 2024.)

The primary window comprises four key panels (see Figure 1). The first panel, **Project Items** (1), showcases the contents of the current project. A project can organize an unlimited number of theoretical models and experimental curves into well-structured folders. The **Structure panel** (2) functions as a visual depiction of the layered model and provides easy access to all parameters linked with the structural model. The right side contains **XRR calculation parameters** (3) and **Fitting parameters** (4) at the top, the main **XRR curve plot** (5) in the center, and **Distributions / Convergence charts** (6) at the bottom.

Left Column — Project Panel

- **File Toolbar:** New, Open, Reopen, Save, Print
- **Project Toolbar:** Add Model, Export, Copy, Paste, Edit Properties, Add Extension, Copy Image, Print, Delete

- **Project Tree:** Hierarchical view of all models, data sets, and folders in the current project
- **Description:** Read-only text memo showing the description of the selected item

Middle Column — Structure Panel

- **Structure Toolbar:** Stack operations ( Add,  Insert,  Delete) and Layer operations ( Add,  Insert,  Copy,  Cut,  Paste,  Delete)
- **Increment Selector:** Step size for quick parameter adjustment (10, 5, 1, 0.25, 0.1, 0.01)
- **Set Fit Limits Button:** Opens the parameter bounds editor for fitting
- **Visual Structure Editor:** Interactive graphical representation of the layer structure — shows Ambient, Stacks (with N repetitions), individual Layers (with H, σ , ρ values), and Substrate. Double-click elements to edit properties; click parameter values for in-place editing.

Right Column — Working Area

- **Calculation Toolbar:**  Load Data,  Paste Data,  Calculate,  Save Result,  Copy Result,  Batch Execute,  Auto Fit, Stop
- **Settings Panel:** Calculation mode and parameters (left half) alongside Fitting mode and parameters (right half)
- **Main Chart:** Interactive reflectivity plot (θ or λ vs. reflectivity)
- **Chart Info Bar:** Cursor position, peak detection, area integration, χ^2 values
- **Chart Pages:** Tabbed sub-charts for parameter distributions (Thickness, Roughness, Density, Profile, Fitting Progress)

Status Bar

Displays calculation time, fitting time, application version, and platform (x64).

Menu Bar

MENU	PURPOSE
File	Project management (New, Open, Save, Settings, Exit)
Project	Model operations (New Model, Duplicate, Copy, Paste, Add Folder)
Structure	Stack and layer editing (Add, Insert, Delete, Copy, Paste, Cut)
Data	Experimental data operations (Load, Paste, Normalize, Smooth, Trim, Export)
Calc	Calculation and fitting (Calculate, Calculate All, Auto Fitting, Batch Jobs, Benchmark)
Result	Export results (Save, Copy to Clipboard, Copy as BMP/WMF)
Tools	Material management (Create Material, Edit Henke Table)
Help	User Manual, About dialog

See Also

- [Quick Reference](#)
- [Projects](#)
- [Charts & Visualization](#)

5 Quick Reference

Toolbar buttons, the structure toolbar, and keyboard shortcuts on one page

Toolbar Quick Reference

BUTTON	ACTION
 New	Create a new project
 Open	Open an existing project
 Save	Save the current project
 Print	Print the current chart
 Add Model	Add a new model to the project
 Load Data	Load experimental data from file
 Paste Data	Paste experimental data from clipboard
 Calc Run	Calculate the selected model
Stop	Abort the current calculation or fitting
 Fast Forward	Start auto-fitting
 Resume Fitting	Continue fitting from the last result, holding frozen parameters — see Staged Fitting
 Result Save	Save calculation results to file
 Copy Result	Copy results to clipboard
Scale	Toggle linear/logarithmic chart scale
 Delete	Remove the selected item

Structure Toolbar

BUTTON	ACTION
 Period +	Add a new stack
 Period Insert	Insert a stack at the current position
 Period -	Delete the selected stack
 Layer +	Add a new layer
 Layer Insert	Insert a layer at the current position
 Layer Copy	Copy the selected layer
 Layer Cut	Cut the selected layer
 Layer Paste	Paste the copied layer
 Layer -	Delete the selected layer
Set Fit Limits	Open the parameter bounds editor
Increment	Set the step size for parameter adjustments

Keyboard Shortcuts

KEY	ACTION
F1	Open User Manual

See Also

- [Application Overview](#)
- [Defining a Model](#)

6 Projects

Project files, creating, opening and saving, auto-save, locking, and the project tree

Project Files

Projects are saved as `.xrcx` files. Internally, an `.xrcx` file is a ZIP archive containing:

- `project.dsc` — project metadata
- `params.dsc` — model structure definitions
- Associated experimental data files

Creating a New Project

1. Choose **File > New Project** (or click the  **New** toolbar button).
2. An empty project is created with no models or data.

Opening a Project

- **File > Open Project** — browse for a `.xrcx` file
- **File > Recent Projects** — select from up to 10 recently opened projects
-  **Open toolbar button** — click the dropdown arrow for recent projects

Saving a Project

- **File > Save Project** — save to the current file
- **File > Save Project As** — save with a new name/location

Auto-Save

When enabled in Settings, the application periodically saves a backup to `AutoSave.xrcx` in the temp directory. This provides crash recovery — on next launch, you will be prompted to restore the auto-saved project.

Project Locking

When a project is open, a lock file (`temp.lock`) prevents simultaneous access from another instance. The lock is released when the project is closed.

Project Tree Organization

The project tree shows items in a hierarchy:

- **Model Group:** Contains all structural models

- Individual models (each with its own layer structure and calculation parameters)
- Extensions (profile functions attached to models)
- **Data Group:** Contains experimental data sets
- **Folders:** User-created organizational folders

Tip: Right-click the project tree for context menu operations.

See Also

- [File Formats > Project File](#)
- [Defining a Model](#)
- [Application Settings](#)

7 Defining a Model

The structure editor, stacks and layers, materials, quick editing, undo, and the JSON view

Creating a Model

- 1. Choose **Project > New Model** or click the  **Add Model** toolbar button.
- 2. A new model appears in the project tree with a default empty structure.

Duplicating a Model

Select a model in the project tree and choose **Project > Duplicate Model** to create an exact copy, including all layers, stacks, and parameters.

The Structure Editor

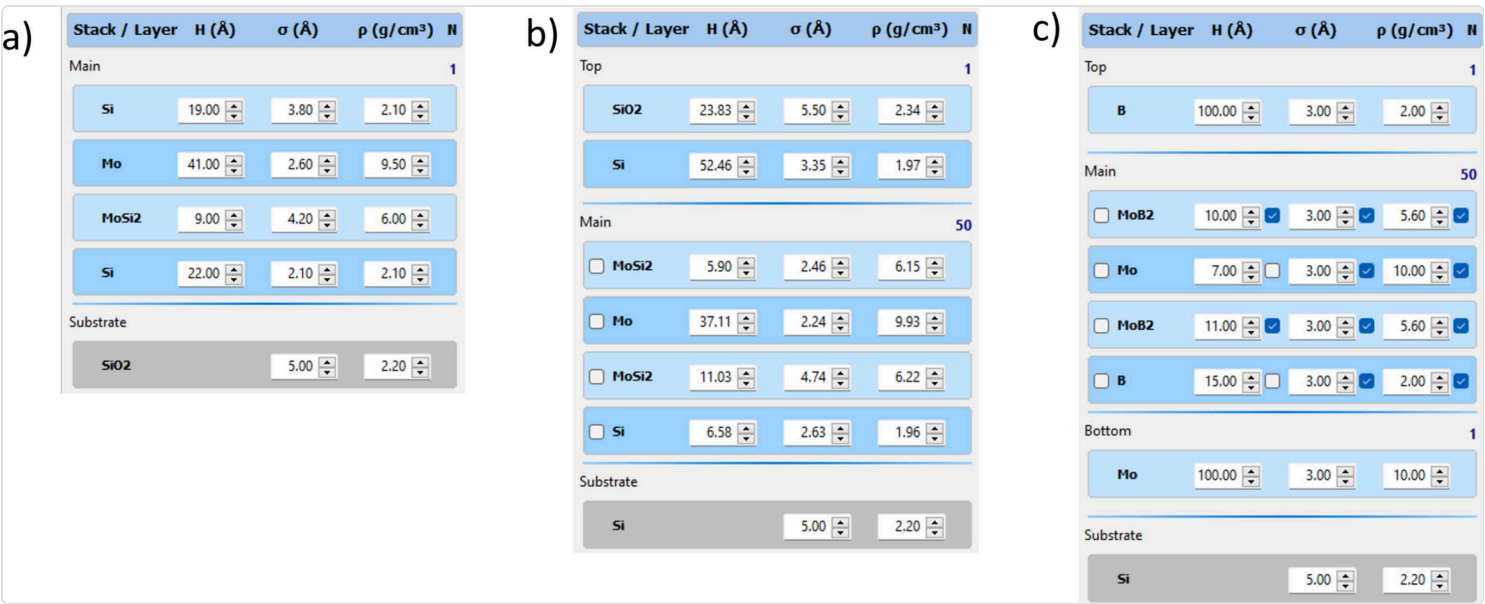


Figure 2. Examples of different structure types. (a) Regular structure. (b) Periodic structure. (c) Periodic structure with distributions. (From Penkov et al., 2024.)

The structure editor is a visual panel in the middle column that displays the current model's layer structure. It shows:

- **Ambient** (top) — the medium above the structure (typically vacuum or air)
- **Stacks** — repeating periodic units containing one or more layers
- **Individual Layers** — single layers outside of stacks
- **Substrate** (bottom) — the base material

Each element in the structure is displayed as a colored block with its parameters.

Terminology

The following terminology is used throughout XRC3 (as defined in Penkov *et al.*, 2024):

- **Material** — the chemical composition of a layer (e.g. Mo, SiO₂, B₄C). Used to look up atomic scattering factors, atomic weights and table densities in the embedded database. Cannot be changed during fitting.
- **Layer** — the basic geometrical entity. A layer consists of a material and has three parameters: thickness (H), roughness (σ) and density (ρ). All three are adjustable during fitting.
- **Stack** — a set of layers. It can be single (non-repeating) or periodic (repeated N times).
- **Structure** — a set of stacks, including a substrate. The substrate is a special stack consisting of a single layer with infinite thickness.

Stacks (Periods)

A stack represents a periodic multilayer structure — a group of layers repeated N times.

Adding a stack

1. Select the model in the project tree.
2. Choose **Structure > Add Stack** or use the structure toolbar.
3. The Stack Properties dialog opens with:
 - **Stack name:** A label for the stack
 - **N:** Number of repetitions (periods)

Editing a stack

Double-click the stack header in the structure editor to open the Stack Properties dialog.

Freezing a stack v3.8.2

Right-click a stack and choose **Freeze stack** to hold all three parameters (H, σ , ρ) of every layer in it during the next fit, or **Thaw stack** to release them. The stack header then reads *[frozen]*, or *[3/6 frozen]* when only part of it is held.

This is the same state the Limits dialog edits in its **Fix** columns, offered where you are already looking when you decide a stack is settled. See [Staged Fitting](#).

Layers

Each layer has three primary parameters:

PARAMETER	SYMBOL	UNIT	DESCRIPTION
Thickness	H	Å (Angstrom)	Physical thickness of the layer
Roughness	σ	Å (Angstrom)	Interface roughness (RMS)
Density	ρ	g/cm ³	Material density

Additionally, each layer has a **material** assignment that links it to an entry in the Henke atomic form factor database.

Adding a layer

1. Select a stack or model in the structure editor.
2. Choose **Structure > Add Layer** or use the  toolbar.
3. The Layer Properties dialog opens with fields for:
 - **Layer material:** Select or type a chemical formula (e.g., "Si", "Mo", "SiO2")
 - **H (Å):** Thickness in Angstroms
 - **σ (Å):** Roughness in Angstroms
 - **ρ (g/cm³):** Density in g/cm³

Navigating layers

The Layer Properties dialog includes << and >> buttons to move to the previous or next layer without closing the dialog.

Layer operations (via Structure menu or toolbar)

-  **Insert Layer** — insert before the selected position
-  **Copy Layer** — copy to internal clipboard
-  **Paste Layer** — paste from internal clipboard
-  **Cut Layer** — copy and delete
-  **Delete Layer** — remove the layer

Quick Parameter Editing

In the structure editor, you can adjust layer parameters directly:

- Click a parameter value to edit it in-place
- Use the **Increment** selector (in the structure toolbar) to set the step size for fine-tuning
- Changes are applied immediately; if Auto-Calc is enabled, the reflectivity recalculates in real time

Undo

Choose **Structure > Undo Structure Changes** to revert the last structural modification.

Model Text (JSON)

For advanced users, **Structure > Edit Model Text** opens a JSON editor showing the raw model definition. This allows direct text editing of the complete structure.

See Also

- [Profile Extensions](#)
- [Tools](#)

- [Fitting > Setting Fit Limits](#)

8 Experimental Data

Loading and pasting measured curves, the data format, normalize, smooth, trim, and export

Loading Data from File

1. Select a model or data item in the project tree.
2. Choose **Data > Load from File** or click the  **Load Data** toolbar button.
3. Browse for a text file containing two-column data (angle/wavelength and reflectivity).
4. The data appears as a series on the main chart.

Pasting Data from Clipboard

1. Copy two-column data from another application (e.g., a spreadsheet).
2. Choose **Data > Paste from Clipboard** or click the  **Paste Data** toolbar button.
3. The data is imported into the current model.

Data Format

The expected data format is a two-column ASCII text file:

- **2 columns** with TAB as the column separator
- **3-row header** (non-numeric lines are skipped automatically)
- Column 1: Angle (degrees) or wavelength (Angstroms)
- Column 2: Reflectivity (typically 0 to 1)

Example:

```
Sample: Mo/Si multilayer
Date: 2024-01-15
Theta      Reflectivity
0.100      1.000000
0.200      0.999850
0.300      0.998200
0.500      0.956300
1.000      0.523100
2.000      0.012450
5.000      0.000023
```

Lines starting with **#** or other non-numeric characters are treated as comments and ignored.

Tip: You can also copy and paste table data directly from **OriginLab Origin**. The recommended workflow is to import your raw data into Origin first, then copy-paste the two-column table into X-Ray Calc.

Data Processing

Normalize

 **Data > Normalize** opens a dialog where you can manually set the normalization factor. This scales the reflectivity values so the maximum equals 1.0 (or another chosen value).

Data > Normalize (Auto) automatically normalizes the data by dividing all reflectivity values by the maximum value.

Smooth

 **Data > Smooth** applies a Savitzky-Golay smoothing filter to reduce noise in the experimental data while preserving peak shapes.

Trim

 **Data > Trim** removes the low-reflectivity tail of the data (values below a threshold), which can improve fitting convergence by eliminating noisy data points at high angles.

Data Conditioning Walkthrough

Raw experimental data often requires conditioning before fitting. Common issues include a long noisy tail, shadowed regions at low angles, noise, and unnormalized intensity. Here is a typical conditioning workflow:

Step 1 — Normalize. Compare the experimental and calculated intensities at a known point (e.g., the total reflection region). Determine the normalization factor and apply it via **Data > Normalize**. For example, if the experimental intensity at 0.4° is 0.099, divide by 0.099 to bring the curve to unit reflectivity.

Step 2 — Smooth. Apply smoothing to reduce noise: **Data > Smooth**. This uses a Savitzky-Golay filter that preserves peak shapes while reducing point-to-point scatter.

Step 3 — Trim. Remove data points outside the useful range:

1. Set the calculation angle range to cover only the reliable portion of the data (e.g., 0.4° to 4.5°).
2. Click **Calc** and note the χ^2 value.
3. Select **Data > Trim** to discard points outside the calculation range.
4. Click **Calc** again — the χ^2 should decrease significantly, confirming that noisy tail data has been removed.

After these steps, the experimental curve is ready for fitting.

Exporting Data

- **Data > Copy to Clipboard** — copy data in tab-separated format for pasting into other applications
- **Data > Export to File** — save processed data to a text file

See Also

- [File Formats > Experimental Data Files](#)
- [Fitting \(Optimization\)](#)

- Troubleshooting

9 Calculation

Theta and lambda modes, polarization, number of points, auto-calculation, and multi-threading

Algorithm

XRC3 uses the Parratt exact recursive method for simulating specular X-ray reflectivity. A Gaussian distribution is assumed for interface roughness. The refractive indices of materials are calculated using the Henke tables of X-ray scattering factors (Henke *et al.*, 1993). Reflectivity calculations can be performed as functions of either incidence angle or wavelength.

Calculation Modes

X-Ray Calc 3 supports two calculation modes:

Theta Mode (by angle)

Calculates reflectivity as a function of incidence angle at a fixed wavelength.

PARAMETER	DESCRIPTION
θ_1	Start angle (degrees)
θ_2	End angle (degrees)
λ (Å)	Fixed wavelength in Angstroms (default: 1.54043 Å, Cu K α)
$\Delta\theta$	Angular resolution / step size (degrees)
2θ	When checked, angles are in 2θ (double angle) convention

Lambda Mode (by wavelength)

Calculates reflectivity as a function of wavelength at a fixed incidence angle.

PARAMETER	DESCRIPTION
λ_1	Start wavelength (Angstroms)
λ_2	End wavelength (Angstroms)
θ	Fixed incidence angle (degrees)
$\Delta\lambda$	Wavelength step size (Angstroms)

Polarization

- **s-type:** S-polarization (TE mode, electric field perpendicular to the plane of incidence)
- **sp-type:** Mixed σ/π polarization

Guidance: Use **s-polarization** when calculating at hard X-rays and low grazing angles (below 20°) — in this regime the difference from sp is negligible and calculation speed is significantly faster. Use **sp-polarization** for larger angles and softer radiation where both polarization components contribute.

Number of Points (N)

The **N** parameter controls the number of calculation points (default: 2000). More points give smoother curves but take longer to compute.

Running a Calculation

1. Select a model in the project tree.
2. Set the calculation parameters (mode, angle/wavelength range, polarization, N).
3. Choose **Calc > Calculate** or click the  **Calc Run** toolbar button.
4. The calculated reflectivity curve appears on the main chart.

Calculate All (**Calc > Calculate All**) calculates reflectivity for every model in the project.

Auto-Calculation

Auto-Calc: When enabled in Settings, the reflectivity is recalculated automatically whenever you modify the structure. This provides real-time feedback as you adjust layer parameters.

Multi-Threading

The complete angular data range is divided into segments matching the number of available CPU cores, and each segment is computed in parallel. Configure the number of cores in **File > Settings > Calc & Fit**:

- **Auto (Use all)** — use all available CPU cores (default)
- **2, 4, 8, 12, 16, 32, 64** — limit to a specific number of threads

Performance: With a 16-core CPU, the typical simulation time for XRR ranges from 0.05 to 0.25 s for a periodic multilayer model consisting of 300 stacks of 4 layers each (3000-point curve). This speed enables real-time manual curve fitting.

See Also

- [Defining a Model](#)
- [Charts & Visualization](#)
- [Application Settings](#)

The Shake LFPSO algorithm, fit limits, fitting modes, parameters, convergence, and the cost function

[illegible]

The LFPSO algorithm creates a population of solutions (particles), each being a vector of structural parameters. The population is iteratively modified to produce better-fitting solutions. The Lévy flight is a random walk that uses the Lévy distribution to determine step sizes, providing efficient global exploration due to occasional long jumps. The Shake modification re-initializes the population when convergence stalls, helping the algorithm escape local minima.

Version 3.6 introduces several [convergence enhancements](#) that improve exploration/exploitation balance, boundary handling, and shake triggering. Six improvements are always active; the Clerc-Kennedy constriction factor is optional (enabled by default in Advanced Settings).

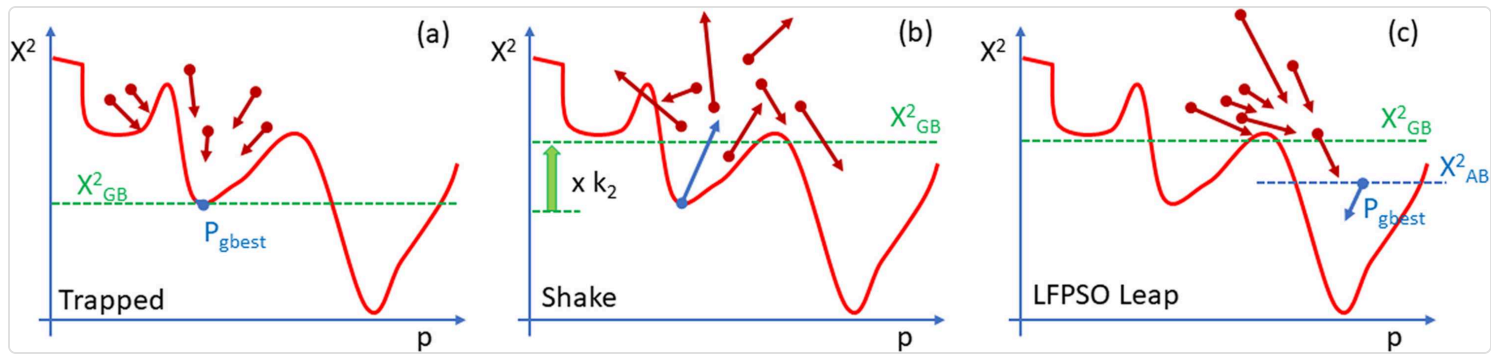


Figure 4. The Shake concept. (a) All particles trapped in a local minimum. (b) Shaking event: locations and velocities are randomized based on P_{gbest} ; V_{max} is multiplied by k_1 and the cost function threshold is lifted by k_2 . (c) After LFPSO leap, a new best solution is found. (From Penkov et al., 2024.)

Prerequisites for Fitting

Before starting a fit, you need:

1. **A defined model** with initial parameter estimates
2. **Experimental data** loaded into the project
3. **Fit limits** set for each adjustable parameter

Setting Fit Limits

1. Select the model in the project tree.
2. Click the **Set Fit Limits** button in the structure toolbar.
3. The Limits dialog opens, showing a table of all layer parameters (H , σ , p), each with a **Fix** column and columns for Min and Max.
4. Click any Min or Max cell to edit its value directly.
5. Only parameters with $\text{Min} \neq \text{Max}$ will be adjusted during fitting. Setting $\text{Min} = \text{Max}$ pins a parameter permanently; to hold one temporarily, freeze it instead (see below).

Freezing Parameters v3.8.2

Freezing holds a parameter at its current value for the next fit *without discarding its limits*. This is the difference between freezing and typing $\text{Min} = \text{Max}$: a frozen parameter keeps the search window you set, so thawing restores exactly that window, and the value it holds follows the model — it tracks the result of every later fit and every manual edit.

- Click a cell in a parameter's **Fix** column to freeze or thaw it. Frozen parameters show **X** and their limits are greyed.
- Select one or more rows and use **Freeze** or **Thaw** to act on whole layers.
- Right-click for **Freeze this stack**, **Freeze this layer**, **Freeze all** and **Thaw all**.
- Each stack's group header counts what is held — *Period stack* — *all 6 frozen* or — *1 of 6 frozen*.

A stack can also be frozen without opening this dialog: right-click it in the structure panel and choose **Freeze stack** or **Thaw stack**. The stack header then shows *[frozen]* or *[3/6 frozen]*, and the two views always agree.

Freeze state is saved in the project file, so it survives closing and reopening. Projects written by earlier versions load with nothing frozen.

Frozen parameters are left alone by **Initialize**, **Narrow**, **Widen** and **Fix**, and are not reported by validation — a frozen parameter with a stale range cannot block a fit.

Limit Actions

The dialog provides action buttons for batch operations on limits:

BUTTON	ACTION
Initialize	Generates limit ranges around current parameter values using the ΔH , $\Delta \sigma$, $\Delta \rho$ percentages. For density (ρ), uses the Henke database bulk density as the center value when available.
Narrow	Shrinks all unlocked limits toward the current fitted value by 50%, reducing the search space. Useful after a successful fit to refine results.
Widen	Expands limits only for parameters where the fitted value sits at a boundary (within 1% of the range edge). Useful when a fit converges to a limit, suggesting the true optimum may lie outside the current range.
Fix	Automatically resolves all detectable problems: swaps inverted Min/Max, adjusts limits to include out-of-range values, widens at-boundary parameters, enforces physics constraints, and applies geometry coupling. Despite the name, this is unrelated to the Fix columns — it repairs limits, it does not freeze anything.
Freeze / Thaw	Holds or releases every parameter of the selected layers. See Freezing Parameters .

Validation and Visual Feedback

The dialog validates limits in real time and highlights problematic cells:

- **Red cells** indicate **errors** that must be fixed before fitting:
 - Min > Max (inverted range)
 - Negative Min for H, σ , or ρ
- **Yellow cells** indicate **warnings** — fitting is allowed but results may be suboptimal:
 - Fitted value below Min or above Max
 - Fitted value at a limit boundary (within 1% of range)
 - Range too wide (>100×) or too narrow (<1% of value)
 - ρ Max exceeds densest stable element (23 g/cm³)
 - All parameters locked — nothing to fit

Click **Fix** to resolve all highlighted issues automatically, or address them manually by editing individual cells.

Physics Constraints

All limit operations automatically enforce physical constraints:

- $H, \sigma, \rho \geq 0$ (no negative values)
- $\rho \leq 23 \text{ g/cm}^3$ (densest stable element, Osmium)
- $\sigma_{\text{Max}} \leq \min(\text{own } H, \text{neighboring layer } H)$ — roughness cannot exceed layer thickness or the thickness of the layer below

Fitting Modes

The software provides several structure-representation methods. The user chooses the most suitable depending on the nature of the coating:

STRUCTURE REPRESENTATION	APPLICABILITY	COMPUTATION TIME
Regular (Irregular)	Regular non-periodic coatings	Long
Periodic	Periodic multilayer mirrors (PMMs)	Short
Periodic with arbitrary deviations	Supermirrors, PMMs with arbitrary distributions	Long
Polynomial distributions	PMMs with gradual change of parameters	Moderate

Irregular Mode

Every parameter of each layer is treated independently. This mode is used for non-periodic coatings consisting of several layers. At the start of fitting, the software expands each periodic stack into individual layers. Once fitting is complete, distribution charts are generated for each parameter of every material type (thickness, roughness, density).

- Each layer has its own fitted thickness, roughness, and density.
- The **Smoothing window** parameter (in Advanced Settings) applies spatial smoothing to prevent unphysical oscillations.
- Specific parameters can be “stack-locked” (paired) — e.g. roughness and density remain constant while thickness varies across the stack.

Example: A Mo/Si PMM with 60 repeated stacks would require 726 variables if treated individually. Using the periodic mode, this reduces to just 18 variables.

Periodic Mode

The coating consists of repeated stacks; each stack consists of several layers. Parameters are fitted per-layer within one period, then applied to all periods. A periodicity keeper normalizes layer thicknesses to maintain the total period D of each stack.

- Suitable for structures with consistent periodicity.
- Dramatically reduces the number of fitting variables for PMMs.

Polynomial Mode

Arbitrary distributions of structural parameters across the stack can be described by polynomial functions of depth. Instead of fitting N individual layer thicknesses, the software fits just a few polynomial coefficients (a_1 – a_k) plus the base value x_0 . The user can select the polynomial order from 1 to 20.

- **Order:** Maximum polynomial order (1 = linear, 2 = quadratic, etc.)
- Useful for smooth, continuous parameter gradients (e.g. graded-period supermirrors, PMMs with unstable deposition rate).

Basic Fitting Parameters

PARAMETER	DESCRIPTION	DEFAULT
Iterations	Maximum number of optimization iterations	100
Population	Number of particles (candidate solutions) in the swarm	100
Shake	Enable random perturbation to escape local minima	Checked
SeedR	Seed particles from the parameter range	Checked
Smooth	Apply smoothing to fitted parameter profiles	Unchecked
PW χ^2	Point-weighted chi-square calculation	Checked
TW χ^2	Theta-weighted chi-square function	None

Theta-Weighted Chi-Square (TW χ^2)

Controls how the chi-square metric weights different angular regions:

OPTION	EFFECT
None	Equal weight across all angles
sqr	Weight $\propto \theta^2$ (emphasizes high angles)
line	Weight $\propto \theta$
sqrt	Weight $\propto \sqrt{\theta}$
1/sqr	Weight $\propto 1/\theta^2$ (emphasizes low angles)
1/sqrt	Weight $\propto 1/\sqrt{\theta}$

Advanced Fitting Settings

Click the **Advanced Settings** button in the Fitting panel to open the detailed LFPSO configuration dialog.

General

PARAMETER	DESCRIPTION	DEFAULT
Tolerance	Target cost function value; fitting stops when reached	0.005
Constriction factor	Use Clerc-Kennedy constriction coefficient ($\chi \approx 0.73$) instead of linear inertia decay. Analytically guarantees convergence. See details below .	Checked

LFPSO Parameters

PARAMETER	DESCRIPTION	DEFAULT
SHmax	Maximum number of consecutive shakes	3
Jmax	Number of iterations without improvement before shake	1
Vmax	Maximum particle velocity factor	0.3
ω_1	Velocity scale factor (permanent component)	0.3
ω_2	Velocity reducing factor	0.1
k_1	Velocity shake coefficient	1.41
k_2	Best cost function shake coefficient	1.41

Irregular Mode Settings

PARAMETER	DESCRIPTION	DEFAULT
Smoothing window	Width of the smoothing window (set -1 for automatic)	3

Polynomial Mode Settings

PARAMETER	DESCRIPTION	DEFAULT
Polynomial factor	Scale factor for polynomial parameter space	10
Ksxr	Velocity scale factor for polynomial coefficients	0.2

Running a Fit

1. Ensure a model with experimental data and fit limits is selected.
2. Configure fitting mode and parameters.
3. Choose **Calc > Auto Fitting** or click the  **Fast Forward** toolbar button.
4. The fitting process begins:
 - The main chart updates in real time, showing the best-fit curve converging toward the experimental data.
 - The **Fitting Progress** chart page shows the χ^2 convergence curve.
 - The status bar displays elapsed fitting time.
 - If **Live Update** is enabled (in Settings), the structure editor updates to show current best-fit parameters.
5. Fitting stops when:
 - The maximum number of iterations is reached, OR
 - The tolerance threshold is met, OR
 - You click the **Stop** button.

Staged Fitting v3.8.2

A complex model rarely fits well in one pass. Staged fitting lets you settle part of it, hold that part still, and concentrate the search on what remains — typically fitting the periodic stack first, then freezing it and working on the top and bottom stacks with a different weighting.

1. Run a fit as usual and let it converge.
2. Freeze the part that has settled — right-click the stack in the structure panel, or use the **Fix** columns in the Limits dialog.
3. Change whatever you want for the next pass, the weight type above all.
4. Choose **Calc > Resume Fitting** or click the  **Resume Fitting** toolbar button.

Resume Fitting is available once a fit has produced a result, and differs from **Auto Fitting** in three ways:

- **It re-centres the search.** Every free parameter's window slides so the value the last fit reached sits at its centre, keeping the width you set. A parameter that ended hard against a boundary can therefore carry on past it, instead of being stuck at the wall.
- **It keeps your fit extensions** without asking. A resumed fit continues from the depth profiles they hold, so the stale-extension prompt would be meaningless there.
- **It continues the convergence chart** rather than clearing it, so both passes are visible on one axis.

The best χ^2 is *not* carried across a resume. Changing the weight type changes what is being minimised, so the two passes' numbers are not on the same scale and comparing them would be misleading.

In Polynomial mode a frozen stack keeps its depth profile: the fit is seeded from the gradient the previous pass produced, so freezing holds the grading rather than flattening it.

Freezing everything leaves nothing to fit, and validation says so.

Convergence Enhancements v3.6

Version 3.6 introduces several improvements to the LFPSO algorithm that significantly improve convergence speed and reliability. Six enhancements are always active and require no configuration; one is optional.

Always-On Improvements

ENHANCEMENT	DESCRIPTION
Reflective boundaries	When a particle exceeds the search domain, it bounces back into the valid range (like a ball hitting a wall) with 0.5× velocity damping, instead of being clamped at the boundary. This prevents particles from “sticking” at limits and keeps them active in the search.
Adaptive Lévy scale	The Lévy flight step size starts large (0.10) for broad exploration and decreases to 0.01 by the end of fitting for fine-tuning. Previously, a fixed value of 0.01 was used throughout.
Adaptive PSO/Lévy switching	Early iterations favor Lévy flights (70%) for exploration; later iterations favor PSO updates (70%) for exploitation. When the algorithm stagnates, Lévy probability increases automatically to escape local minima. Previously, a fixed 50/50 split was used.
Random-peer Lévy targets	30% of Lévy flights are directed toward a randomly chosen peer particle instead of the global best. This creates diverse search directions and helps explore regions that global-best targeting would miss — particularly valuable for the multimodal fitness landscapes common in X-ray reflectivity.
Population diversity monitoring	The algorithm now tracks the normalized spread of particle positions across all parameters, providing a measure of how converged or diverse the swarm is.
Diversity-aware shake	The shake mechanism now checks population diversity before triggering. If the swarm is still diverse (spread ≥ 1% of parameter ranges), the shake is delayed for up to 3 additional iterations to let ongoing exploration proceed. If diversity has collapsed (< 1%), the shake fires immediately. This prevents premature reinitializations that waste computation.

Constriction Factor (Optional)

When the **Constriction factor** checkbox is enabled in Advanced Settings, the standard linear inertia weight decay is replaced by the Clerc-Kennedy constriction coefficient:

$$\mathbf{V} = \chi \times (\mathbf{V} + \varphi_1 \mathbf{r}_1 (\mathbf{p}_{\text{best}} - \mathbf{X}) + \varphi_2 \mathbf{r}_2 (\mathbf{g}_{\text{best}} - \mathbf{X}))$$

where $\varphi = \varphi_1 + \varphi_2 = 4.1$, $\chi = 2 / |2 - \varphi - \sqrt{\varphi^2 - 4\varphi}| \approx 0.7298$

Unlike the empirical linear schedule, the constriction coefficient is mathematically proven to guarantee convergence while maintaining effective exploration. The higher cognitive and social coefficients ($\varphi_1 = \varphi_2 = 2.05$ vs. the previous $c_1 = c_2 = 1$) give particles stronger attraction to good solutions, while the constriction factor prevents velocity explosion.

When to use: The constriction factor is enabled by default and is recommended for most problems. Consider disabling it if you notice premature convergence on problems with many sharp local minima — the linear inertia decay may provide more aggressive exploration in such cases. When disabled, the ω_1 and ω_2 parameters in the LFPSO section control the inertia schedule.

Understanding the Cost Function

The cost function (E) measures the deviation between the calculated and target XRR curves:

$$E = \sum |\log I(\theta)_{\text{exp}} - \log I(\theta)_{\text{calc}}| \times \omega(\theta)_{\text{peak}} \times \omega(\theta)_{\theta}$$

where $I(\theta)_{\text{exp}}$ and $I(\theta)_{\text{calc}}$ are the measured and computed XRR intensities, $\omega(\theta)_{\text{peak}}$ is the peak weight function, and $\omega(\theta)_{\theta}$ is the incidence-angle weight function.

Peak Weight Function (PW χ^2)

Specifically designed for periodic multilayer mirrors. Parameters of the periodic stack primarily affect the intensity of primary diffraction peaks, while Kiessig fringes are affected by the substrate and surface layers. The peak weight function concentrates fitting on the primary features of the XRR curve by computing a moving average and weighting points based on their deviation from it.

Incidence-Angle Weight Function (TW χ^2)

Allows concentration of the fitting process on distinct segments of the XRR curve by weighting different angular regions differently.

Key properties of the cost function:

- **Lower is better** — $E = 0$ means a perfect fit
- Displayed in the Chart Info bar as both current and best values
- Calculated on a logarithmic scale to give equal weight to both high and low reflectivity regions

See Also

- [Experimental Data](#)
- [Results & Export](#)
- [Illustrative Examples](#)
- [MCP Server > Fitting](#)

11 Results & Export

Saving results, the clipboard, plot and structure images, and auto-saved fits

Saving Results

 **Result > Save Results** saves the calculated reflectivity data to a text file with columns for angle/wavelength and reflectivity.

Copying to Clipboard

-  **Result > Copy to Clipboard** — copy reflectivity data as tab-separated text
-  **Result > Copy as BMP** — copy the chart as a bitmap image
- **Result > Copy as WMF** — copy the chart as a Windows Metafile (vector format, suitable for publications)

Saving the Plot

Result > Save Plot as File saves the chart as an image file.

Structure Image

Structure > Copy as Image copies the visual structure diagram (the layer/stack representation) to the clipboard as an image.

Auto-Save Results

When enabled in Settings (**Automatically save results to output folder after fitting**), fitting results are automatically saved to the configured Output directory after each fitting run completes.

See Also

- [Fitting \(Optimization\)](#)
- [Charts & Visualization](#)

12 Charts & Visualization

The reflectivity chart, zoom and pan, cursor tracking, chart pages, and peak analysis

Main Reflectivity Chart

The large chart in the working area displays:

- **Calculated reflectivity curves** (one per model, color-coded)
- **Experimental data** (if loaded)
- **Best-fit curve** (during and after fitting)

Interaction

- **Zoom:** Click and drag to select a zoom region
- **Pan:** Right-click and drag to pan
- **Reset zoom:** Double-click to reset to full view
- **Scale toggle:** Click the **Scale** button to switch between linear and logarithmic Y-axis
- **Min limit:** Set a cutoff threshold — reflectivity values below this limit are clipped

Cursor Tracking

The Chart Info bar shows the current cursor position (X, Y coordinates) as you move the mouse over the chart.

Chart Pages

Below the main chart are tabbed sub-charts:

Thickness (H)

Bar chart showing the thickness of each layer in the structure. After fitting, this shows how layer thicknesses vary across the structure.

Roughness (σ)

Bar chart showing the interface roughness of each layer. Useful for identifying roughness trends in periodic structures.

Density (ρ)

Bar chart showing the density of each layer, with the applied density profile overlaid.

Profile

Electron density (or refractive index) profile as a function of depth into the structure. This gives a physical picture of the complete multilayer structure.

Fitting Progress

During fitting, this chart shows the χ^2 value vs. iteration number. Use this to monitor convergence:

- A steadily decreasing curve indicates good convergence
 - Plateaus may indicate local minima (shake/re-initialization helps escape these)
 - Sudden jumps up indicate a shake event
-

Peak Analysis

The Chart Info bar includes peak detection and analysis:

- **Peak Max:** Maximum reflectivity value and its position
- **Area:** Integrated area under the peak (useful for quantitative analysis)
- **Period:** Estimated multilayer period from peak spacing

See Also

- [Calculation](#)
- [Results & Export](#)

13 Profile Extensions

Function and table profiles that vary a parameter across a periodic structure

Profile extensions allow you to define how layer parameters (H , σ , ρ) vary across a periodic structure. They model parameter gradients — for example, when layer thickness gradually increases or density changes with depth.

Adding a Profile Extension

1. Select a model in the project tree.
2. Click the  **Add Extension** toolbar button or choose the extension option from the project toolbar.
3. The Extension Type Selector dialog opens with available profile types.

Profile Types

Function Profile

Defines parameter variation using an analytical function:

FUNCTION	FORMULA	USE CASE
Polynomial	$a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2 + \dots$	General-purpose gradient
Exponential	$a_0 \cdot e^{a_1x}$	Exponential growth/decay
Parabolic	$a_0 + a_1x^2$	Symmetric variation
SQRT	$a_0 + a_1\sqrt{x}$	Gradual initial change

The Profile Function editor lets you set the coefficients and preview the resulting profile.

Table Profile

Defines parameter variation as a set of (position, value) data points. The application interpolates between points. This allows arbitrary profile shapes that cannot be described by simple functions.

The Profile Table editor provides a grid where you enter depth positions and corresponding parameter values.

Enabling / Disabling Extensions

Each extension can be individually enabled or disabled without deleting it. This lets you quickly compare results with and without a particular profile applied.

See Also

- [Defining a Model > Stacks](#)
- [Fitting > Fitting Modes](#)

14 Tools

Creating materials, editing Henke tables, and the benchmark

Create New Material

 **Tools > Create New Material** opens a dialog to add a custom material to the Henke database.

Enter the chemical formula and the application calculates the atomic form factors from the constituent elements. This is useful for compounds not already in the database.

Edit Henke Table

 **Tools > Edit Henke Table** opens the Henke Table Editor, which allows you to view and modify the atomic scattering factor tables used for reflectivity calculations.

The Henke tables contain wavelength-dependent atomic form factors (f_1 , f_2) for each element. These are the fundamental optical constants used in the Fresnel equation calculations.

Benchmark

 **Calc > Benchmark** opens the Benchmark dialog, which measures the calculation performance of your system:

- Runs a standard reflectivity calculation multiple times
- Reports average execution time
- Useful for comparing performance across different hardware or thread configurations

Configure the number of benchmark runs in **File > Settings > Calc & Fit**.

See Also

- [Defining a Model](#)
- [File Formats > Henke Tables](#)

15 Application Settings

Paths and files, behavior, interface, calculation and fitting defaults, graphics

Access settings via **File > Settings**. The Settings dialog has five sections, navigated via the tree on the left.

Paths and Files

SETTING	DESCRIPTION
Default Project's Folder	Where new projects are saved by default
Work Folder	Base directory for all application data
Henke Library	Location of Henke atomic form factor tables
Jobs	Directory for batch job definitions
Benchmark output	Where benchmark results are saved
Benchmark	Location of benchmark model files
Fitting Output	Where fitting results are auto-saved

Register file associations (**xrcx**) — associates `.xrcx` files with X-Ray Calc 3 in Windows.

Behavior

SETTING	DESCRIPTION	DEFAULT
Automatically calculate when opening project	Run calculation on all models when a project is opened	On
Live update structure panel during fitting	Show real-time parameter changes in the structure editor during fitting	Off
Automatically save results to output folder after fitting	Save fitting results to the Output directory automatically	Off
Automatically check for updates	Check for new versions on launch	Off

Interface

Interface customization settings (reserved for future options).

Calc & Fit

SETTING	DESCRIPTION	DEFAULT
Number of CPU cores to use	Thread count for parallel computation	Auto (Use all)
Number of runs (Benchmark)	How many benchmark iterations to perform	10

Graphics

SETTING	DESCRIPTION	DEFAULT
Default line width	Width of chart series lines in pixels	2

See Also

- [Installation & First Launch](#)
- [File Formats > Settings File](#)

16 Universal Mirror Optimizer v3.7

Command-line design of multi-wavelength multilayer mirrors with LFPSO: configuration, output, resume, figure of merit

The **Universal Mirror Optimizer** is a command-line tool that designs periodic multilayer mirrors (PMMs) optimized for *multiple characteristic wavelengths simultaneously*. Given a set of target elements (e.g. C K α and O K α), the optimizer searches for the best combination of materials, period thickness, layer ratio, number of periods, and interface roughness to maximize reflectivity across all targets at once.

This tool is part of the `xrccmd` command-line interface and uses the same Fresnel reflectivity engine and Henke optical constants database as the main X-Ray Calc 3 GUI application.

Concept

Traditional multilayer mirror design targets a single wavelength. When an analytical instrument (e.g. an electron microprobe or X-ray fluorescence spectrometer) needs to measure multiple characteristic lines, the standard approach is to use separate mirrors for each element. The Universal Mirror Optimizer explores whether a single bilayer structure can provide useful reflectivity at two or more wavelengths simultaneously, even if it compromises peak performance at any single wavelength.

The optimizer uses the **Virtual Crystal Approximation** (VCA) to model mixed-material layers. Each layer's composition is defined as a weighted mixture of elements from a user-defined pool (e.g. W, Si, C). The dielectric constant of the mixed material is computed as a weighted average of the constituents' optical constants from the Henke database.

Search Space

The optimizer searches over the following parameters:

PARAMETER	DESCRIPTION
Composition (per layer)	Element fractions for each layer in the bilayer period. Fractions are normalized to sum to 1.0.
d	Period thickness in Ångströms
γ (gamma)	Ratio of the reflector layer thickness to the full period (0–1)
N	Number of periods (rounded to integer for evaluation)
σ (sigma)	Interface roughness in Ångströms (shared by all interfaces)
Density factor (per layer)	Multiplier on the bulk density of each layer (0.7–1.3 typical), accounting for thin-film density deviations

Optimization Algorithm

The optimizer uses **Lévy Flight Particle Swarm Optimization** (LFPSO) with the same adaptive enhancements as the GUI fitting engine (see [Chapter 9: Convergence Enhancements](#)). Key features include:

- Adaptive PSO/Lévy flight switching (more exploration early, more exploitation late)

- Reflective boundary handling with velocity damping
- Composition normalization (fractions always sum to 1.0)
- Diversity-aware shake mechanism for stagnation escape
- Parallel fitness evaluation using all available CPU cores

CLI Usage

The Universal Mirror Optimizer is invoked via the `xrccmd` command-line tool with the `-u` switch:

```
xrccmd -u config.json [-v]
```

SWITCH	DESCRIPTION
<code>-u config.json</code>	Run the Universal Mirror Optimizer with the specified JSON configuration file
<code>-v</code>	Verbose mode — prints checkpoint saves and shake events during optimization

Console Output

During optimization, the console displays a progress table updated every iteration:

```
Universal Mirror Optimizer v1.0
Targets: C(44.7A) O(23.6A)
Pool: W Si C
Structure: bilayer, d=[20..80], N=[20..100]
Population: 100, Max iterations: 500
---
  Iter      FoM    R_C    R_O    Div
    0      0.0124  0.012  0.003  0.438
    1      0.0298  0.031  0.009  0.412
    2      0.0356  0.037  0.015  0.391
    ...
   500      0.1823  0.187  0.044  0.003
---
Optimization complete.
Best FoM: 0.182300
Period d=54.94 A, gamma=0.697, N=36, sigma=0.72 A
Layer 1: C=100.0%
Layer 2: W=32.7% Si=35.8% C=31.5%
```

Columns: **Iter** = iteration number, **FoM** = figure of merit (higher is better), **R_X** = peak reflectivity for each target element, **Div** = population diversity (0–1, lower = more converged).

Configuration File

The optimizer is configured via a JSON file with the following sections:

Targets

An array of target characteristic lines to optimize for:

```
"targets": [
  {"element": "C", "lambda": 44.7, "weight": 1.0},
  {"element": "O", "lambda": 23.6, "weight": 1.0}
]
```

FIELD	TYPE	DESCRIPTION
element	string	Element name (used for labeling output)
lambda	number	Characteristic wavelength in Ångströms (e.g. C K α = 44.7 Å)
weight	number	Relative weight in the figure of merit. Use higher values to prioritize specific targets.

Element Pool

The set of materials available for layer composition:

```
"element_pool": ["W", "Si", "C"]
```

Each element must have a corresponding Henke database file (`.bin`) in the Henke data directory. The optimizer can mix any combination of these elements in each layer.

Structure

Defines the mirror topology and parameter search ranges:

```
"structure": {
  "type": "bilayer",
  "layers_per_period": 2,
  "pure_elements": true,
  "d": {"min": 20, "max": 80},
  "gamma": {"min": 0.2, "max": 0.8},
  "N": {"min": 20, "max": 100},
  "sigma": {"min": 0.5, "max": 3},
  "density_factor": {"min": 0.7, "max": 1.3}
}
```

FIELD	TYPE	DESCRIPTION
type	string	Structure type. Currently only "bilayer" is supported (two layers per period).
layers_per_period	integer	Must be 2 for bilayer mode.
pure_elements	boolean	When true, each layer is forced to use a single material from the pool (the dominant component). When false, layers can be arbitrary mixtures. Pure-element mode is recommended for most practical applications.
d	range	Period thickness search range in Å. Ensure the range accommodates all target wavelengths ($d > \lambda/2$ for a valid Bragg condition).
gamma	range	Reflector/period thickness ratio (0–1). Layer 1 thickness = $d \times \gamma$, Layer 2 = $d \times (1 - \gamma)$.
N	range	Number of bilayer periods. More periods give sharper peaks but tighter angular tolerance.
sigma	range	Interface roughness in Å. Shared by all interfaces in the structure.
density_factor	range	Density multiplier range for each layer. 1.0 = bulk density. Values < 1 model porous or amorphous films; values > 1 model compressive stress.

Bragg condition: The period d must satisfy $\lambda/(2d) < 1$ for each target wavelength, otherwise no Bragg peak exists. For a target at $\lambda = 44.7$ Å, the minimum period is $d > 22.35$ Å.

Fitness

Controls the figure of merit calculation:

```
"fitness": {
  "w_R": 1.0,
  "w_FWHM": 0.3,
  "R_min_threshold": 0.0001,
  "polarization": "sp",
  "delta_theta": 0.1,
  "theta_min": 3.0,
  "w_purity": 1.0
}
```

FIELD	TYPE	DESCRIPTION
<code>w_R</code>	number	Weight for peak reflectivity in the FoM. Higher values emphasize maximizing R_{peak} .
<code>w_FWHM</code>	number	Weight for the FWHM penalty. Higher values penalize broad peaks. Set to 0 to ignore bandwidth.
<code>R_min_threshold</code>	number	Minimum acceptable peak reflectivity. Particles below this threshold receive a heavy penalty (100.0) to drive the swarm away from “dark” solutions.
<code>polarization</code>	string	Polarization mode: “sp” for averaged S+P (recommended for most applications).
<code>delta_theta</code>	number	Instrumental angular resolution in degrees. The calculated reflectivity curve is convolved with a Gaussian of this width before extracting R_{peak} and FWHM.
<code>theta_min</code>	number	Minimum acceptable Bragg angle in degrees. Targets whose Bragg angle falls below this value receive a heavy penalty. Prevents solutions at impractically low grazing angles.
<code>w_purity</code>	number	Weight for the spectral purity penalty (0–1). Controls how strongly higher-order Bragg peak contamination between targets is penalized. 0 = no purity penalty, 1 = full penalty. Default: 1.0. See Spectral Purity .
<code>scan_points</code>	integer	Number of points in the reflectivity scan around each Bragg peak. Higher values give finer theta resolution in output curves. Default: 200.
<code>scan_half_range</code>	number	Half-range of the reflectivity scan in degrees, centered on the Bragg peak. The scan covers $[\theta_{\text{Bragg}} - \text{half_range}, \theta_{\text{Bragg}} + \text{half_range}]$. Default: 5.0.

Optimizer

LFPSO algorithm parameters:

```

"optimizer": {
  "population": 100,
  "iterations": 500,
  "tolerance": 1e-8,
  "stagnation_limit": 50,
  "w1": 0.4,
  "w2": 0.5,
  "jamming_max": 5,
  "checkpoint_every": 50
}

```

FIELD	TYPE	DEFAULT	DESCRIPTION
<code>population</code>	integer	—	Number of particles (candidate solutions) in the swarm. Larger populations explore more broadly but run slower per iteration.
<code>iterations</code>	integer	—	Maximum number of optimization iterations.
<code>tolerance</code>	number	1e-8	Target FoM threshold (not actively used for early stopping; kept for future use).
<code>stagnation_limit</code>	integer	50	Number of iterations without improvement before the optimizer declares convergence and stops.
<code>w1</code>	number	0.4	PSO inertia weight (permanent velocity component).
<code>w2</code>	number	0.5	PSO inertia reducing factor (decays over iterations).
<code>jamming_max</code>	integer	5	Iterations without improvement before a shake event is considered (subject to diversity check).
<code>checkpoint_every</code>	integer	50	Save a checkpoint file every N iterations. Set to 0 to disable periodic checkpoints.

Recommended settings: For a 3-element pool with 2 targets, `population: 100` and `iterations: 500` is a good starting point. Increase population for larger element pools. Reduce iterations for quick exploratory runs.

Top-Level Fields

```
"substrate": "Si",
"henke_path": null,
"output_dir": "./results",
"resume_from": null
```

FIELD	TYPE	DESCRIPTION
<code>substrate</code>	string	Substrate material (used for the bottom layer of the mirror structure).
<code>henke_path</code>	string or null	Path to the Henke database directory. <code>null</code> uses the default location next to the executable (<code>Henke/</code>).
<code>output_dir</code>	string	Directory where all output files are written. Created automatically if it does not exist.
<code>resume_from</code>	string or null	Path to a checkpoint file to resume from. <code>null</code> starts a fresh optimization. See Checkpoint & Resume .

Output Files

The optimizer writes several files to the `output_dir` upon completion:

FILE	DESCRIPTION
<code>best_structure.json</code>	The optimized mirror structure in XRC3-compatible JSON format, including the full genome (composition, period, gamma, N, sigma), per-target reflectivity results (R_{peak} , FWHM, θ_{Bragg}), and a structure definition that can be imported into the GUI.
<code>best_curves/Element.dat</code>	Tab-separated reflectivity curves for each target element. Two columns: angle (degrees) and reflectivity. One file per target.
<code>population.json</code>	The top 10 solutions ranked by FoM. Useful for comparing alternative mirror designs that may trade off performance between targets differently.
<code>checkpoint.json</code>	Full optimizer state (all particle positions, velocities, and personal bests). Used for resuming interrupted runs.
<code>progress.log</code>	Plain text log of every iteration's FoM, per-target R_{peak} , and population diversity. Matches the console output.

best_structure.json Format

The output structure file contains two sections:

- **optimizer_result** — numerical results: FoM, structural parameters (d , γ , N , σ), layer compositions, and per-element reflectivity metrics.
- **structure** — the mirror definition in a format compatible with the X-Ray Calc 3 project file. Contains the periodic bilayer stack and substrate definition with layer thickness, roughness, and density factor values.

Reflectivity Curve Files

Each `.dat` file in the `best_curves/` subdirectory contains a 200-point reflectivity scan centered on the Bragg angle $\pm 5^\circ$ for that target wavelength. The data is tab-separated with columns:

```

angle(deg)    reflectivity
3.2400        1.23456789e-03
3.2900        2.34567890e-03
...
```

Checkpoint & Resume

Long optimization runs can be interrupted (Ctrl+C) and resumed later. The optimizer handles this gracefully:

1. **Automatic checkpoints** — saved every `checkpoint_every` iterations to `checkpoint.json` in the output directory.
2. **Ctrl+C handling** — when the user presses Ctrl+C, the optimizer saves a final checkpoint before exiting. No data is lost.
3. **Resume** — set `"resume_from"` in the configuration file to the path of a checkpoint file. The optimizer restores all particle positions, velocities, personal bests, and the global/all-time best, then continues from where it left off.

Example resume configuration:

```

{
  "targets": [...],
  "element_pool": ["W", "Si", "C"],
  ...
  "optimizer": {
    "population": 100,
    "iterations": 1000,
    ...
  },
  "output_dir": "./results",
  "resume_from": "./results/checkpoint.json"
}

```

Important: When resuming, the `population` size and `element_pool` must match the checkpoint. The `iterations` count can be increased to allow more optimization cycles.

Figure of Merit

The figure of merit (FoM) combines peak reflectivity and angular bandwidth for all target wavelengths:

$$\text{FoM} = \sum_i [\text{weight}_i \times (w_R \times R_{\text{eff},i} - w_{\text{FWHM}} \times \text{FWHM}_i / \text{FWHM}_{\text{ref},i})]$$

where:

- $R_{\text{eff},i}$ — effective reflectivity for target i , which equals $R_{\text{peak},i}$ when `w_purity` is 0, or purity-adjusted reflectivity when `w_purity` > 0 (see [Spectral Purity](#))
- $R_{\text{peak},i}$ — peak reflectivity (0–1) for target i , extracted from a 200-point scan around the Bragg angle
- FWHM_i — angular full width at half maximum (degrees) of the Bragg peak
- $\text{FWHM}_{\text{ref},i}$ — theoretical minimum $\text{FWHM} = \lambda / (N \cdot d \cdot \cos\theta_B)$, converted to degrees. Normalizes the FWHM penalty so it is comparable across targets.
- weight_i — per-target weight from the configuration
- w_R, w_{FWHM} — global weights for reflectivity and bandwidth terms

Higher FoM is better. Particles with R_{peak} below `R_min_threshold` for any target receive a heavy penalty (100.0 per dark target) to steer the swarm toward functional solutions.

Spectral Purity

When optimizing a mirror for multiple characteristic wavelengths, higher-order Bragg reflections can cause **cross-contamination** between measurement channels. For example, a mirror tuned to O K α (23.6 Å) at its first-order Bragg angle will also reflect wavelengths at $\lambda/2 = 11.8$ Å via the second order — which nearly coincides with Na K α (11.9 Å). When both O and Na are among the target elements, any Na fluorescence reaching the detector at the O measurement angle is misattributed to O.

The spectral purity penalty addresses this by computing a **cross-reflectivity matrix** and penalizing solutions where contamination is significant.

Cross-Reflectivity Matrix

For each pair of targets i and j , the optimizer computes:

$$\text{CrossR}[j, i] = R(\theta_j, \lambda_i)$$

This is the reflectivity of light with wavelength λ_i hitting the mirror at the Bragg angle of target j . A high value of $\text{CrossR}[j, i]$ means that when the spectrometer measures target j , it also picks up signal from target i 's wavelength via higher-order reflection. The calculation uses the full multilayer reflectivity at each (θ, λ) point — all Bragg orders are naturally included.

Purity and Effective Reflectivity

For each target j , the **purity** is defined as:

$$\text{Purity}_j = R_{\text{peak},j} / (R_{\text{peak},j} + \sum_{i \neq j} \text{CrossR}[j, i])$$

Purity ranges from 0 (entirely contaminated) to 1 (no contamination). The effective reflectivity used in the FoM is then:

$$R_{\text{eff},j} = R_{\text{peak},j} \times (1 + w_{\text{purity}} \times (\text{Purity}_j - 1))$$

When $w_{\text{purity}} = 0$, $R_{\text{eff}} = R_{\text{peak}}$ (no penalty). When $w_{\text{purity}} = 1$, $R_{\text{eff}} = R_{\text{peak}} \times \text{Purity}$, giving maximum penalization of contaminated channels. Intermediate values blend between the two.

Physical Background

Higher-order contamination depends on two structural factors:

- **γ (layer ratio)** — controls which orders are suppressed. $\gamma = 0.5$ completely eliminates all even-order reflections (2nd, 4th, ...). Values far from 0.5 produce strong even-order peaks. Second-order contamination is typically the most significant.
- **σ (roughness)** — interfacial roughness attenuates higher orders via the Debye-Waller factor, which decays exponentially with order number. Orders above 4–5 are generally negligible for typical roughness values.

Practical note: The overlap pattern is inherent to the target wavelength set — second-order overlap at $\lambda/2$ is independent of the period d . The optimizer can only mitigate overlaps through γ (order suppression), material choice (absorption edges), and roughness. For large element pools with many close-spaced wavelengths, use $w_{\text{purity}} = 1.0$ and a population ≥ 500 to give the optimizer enough room to find purity-optimized solutions.

Example Workflow

This example designs a multilayer mirror for simultaneous C K α (44.7 Å) and O K α (23.6 Å) characterization using W/Si/C materials on a Si substrate.

Step 1: Create the configuration file

Save the following as `dual_mirror.json`:

```
{
  "targets": [
    {"element": "C", "lambda": 44.7, "weight": 1.0},
    {"element": "O", "lambda": 23.6, "weight": 1.0}
  ],
  "element_pool": ["W", "Si", "C"],
  "structure": {
    "type": "bilayer",
    "layers_per_period": 2,
    "d": {"min": 20, "max": 80},
    "gamma": {"min": 0.2, "max": 0.8},
    "N": {"min": 20, "max": 100},
    "sigma": {"min": 0.5, "max": 3},
    "density_factor": {"min": 0.7, "max": 1.3}
  },
  "fitness": {
    "w_R": 1.0,
    "w_FWHM": 0.3,
    "R_min_threshold": 0.0001,
    "polarization": "sp"
  },
  "optimizer": {
    "population": 100,
    "iterations": 500,
    "tolerance": 1e-8,
    "stagnation_limit": 50,
    "w1": 0.4,
    "w2": 0.5,
    "jamming_max": 5,
    "checkpoint_every": 50
  },
  "substrate": "Si",
  "henke_path": null,
  "output_dir": "./dual_mirror_results",
  "resume_from": null
}
```

Step 2: Run the optimizer

```
xrccmd -u dual_mirror.json -v
```

The `-v` flag enables verbose output, showing checkpoint saves and shake events. A typical run with population 100 and 500 iterations takes a few minutes on a modern multi-core CPU.

Step 3: Review results

After completion, examine the output directory:

- `dual_mirror_results/best_structure.json` — the optimal mirror design and its performance
- `dual_mirror_results/best_curves/C.dat` — reflectivity curve at C K α (44.7 Å)
- `dual_mirror_results/best_curves/O.dat` — reflectivity curve at O K α (23.6 Å)
- `dual_mirror_results/population.json` — top 10 alternative solutions

The reflectivity curve files can be plotted in any graphing tool (Origin, gnuplot, Python/matplotlib) or imported into the X-Ray Calc 3 GUI for comparison with experimental data.

Step 4: Continue optimization (optional)

If you want to refine the result further, increase the iteration count and add a resume path:

```
{
  ...
  "optimizer": {
    "population": 100,
    "iterations": 1000,
    ...
  },
  "resume_from": "./dual_mirror_results/checkpoint.json"
}
```

Then re-run: `xrccmd -u dual_mirror.json -v`

Tips and Best Practices

- **Start small, then refine.** Begin with a small population (20–50) and few iterations (50–100) to verify the configuration produces sensible results, then increase for production runs.
- **Element pool size.** Each additional element adds composition dimensions for each layer. Pools of 3–5 elements work well. Very large pools may require larger populations.
- **Period range.** Ensure $d_{\min} > \lambda_{\max}/2$ so all targets have valid Bragg conditions. A generous range (e.g. 20–80 Å) allows the optimizer to find the best compromise period.
- **Weighting targets.** If one target is more important, increase its `weight` in the configuration. The optimizer will prioritize that target's reflectivity at the expense of the others.
- **Interpreting diversity.** A diversity value near zero means all particles have converged to similar solutions. If diversity drops quickly but FoM is still low, consider increasing the population or widening the search ranges.
- **Population JSON.** The `population.json` file contains up to 10 distinct solutions. These often reveal physically different mirror designs (different compositions or periods) with similar overall FoM. Examining them can provide insight into the design trade-space.

See Also

- [MCP Server > Optimisation and Jobs](#)
- [Fitting \(Optimization\)](#)

17 MCP Server (XRC_MCP)

Connect an AI assistant to the calculation engine through the Model Context Protocol

Overview

XRC_MCP is a console program that exposes the X-Ray Calc 3 calculation engine to AI assistants over the **Model Context Protocol** (MCP). An MCP client such as Claude Code starts `XRC_MCP.exe`, talks to it as JSON-RPC 2.0 over standard input and output, and calls its **tools**: calculate a reflectivity curve, score a mirror design, run the universal optimizer, fit a measured curve, and read or write `.xrcx` project files.

The engines are the GUI's own. The curve, the χ^2 and the figure of merit the server returns are the numbers X-Ray Calc 3 and XRFCalc display for the same structure, and a fit written by the server opens in the GUI as an ordinary project file. This lets you have an assistant prepare, run and compare fits while you verify every result in the GUI.

PROPERTY	VALUE
Executable	<code>XRC_MCP.exe</code> , 64-bit only, in the same folder as the GUI
Transport	JSON-RPC 2.0 over stdio; one JSON object per line, UTF-8
Tools	16, grouped below
Long jobs	<code>optimize_mirror</code> and <code>fit_xrr</code> run in the background and are polled
Record	Every call and result appended to <code>log\calls.jsonl</code>

Installation and Registration

The server needs no configuration file. It takes one mandatory argument, the **working directory** that becomes its sandbox (see [below](#)):

```
XRC_MCP.exe --workdir "D:\Experiments\RuC-2026-09"
```

Register it with Claude Code once per experiment directory. The name `xrc` is how the assistant refers to the server:

```
claude mcp add -s user xrc -- "C:\Program Files\X-RayCalc3\XRC_MCP.exe" --workdir "D:\Experiments\RuC-
```

Other MCP clients register a stdio server the same way: the command is the path to `XRC_MCP.exe`, the arguments are `--workdir` and an absolute path. Nothing in the server depends on the current directory of the process.

To verify the registration, ask the assistant to call `describe_server`. The reply states the server version, the git revision it was built from, the Henke table directory in use, the unit conventions, and a one-line summary of

every tool.

OmniThreadLibrary 3.08: If you build the server yourself, it needs OmniThreadLibrary 3.08 or later. With an older library a job stays at iteration 0 for ever and the server will not exit. See [Source Code](#) > [Dependencies](#).

The Working Directory

Every path the server reads or writes lies under the working directory. It is created on first start with four subfolders:

```
<workdir>\
  projects\      .xrcx files the server writes (save_project) and reads (load_project)
  jobs\          one folder per job: request, progress log, curves, results
  inbox\         measured curves that YOU put there; the server never writes here
  <specimen>\    one folder per specimen, any number of data files inside
  log\
    calls.jsonl  every tools/call and its result, appended, never truncated
```

A path argument that resolves outside the working directory (a rooted path, a drive letter, a UNC path, or a `..` segment) is refused with the error `path_outside_workdir` ; it is never silently remapped.

The journal is the record. `log\calls.jsonl` holds one line per call with a timestamp, the tool name, the full arguments and the full result or error. Long numeric arrays such as curves are replaced by their length and the SHA-256 of the file they were written to. Keep it with the experiment.

Units and the Structure JSON

The conventions are the program's: thickness, roughness σ and wavelength in **ångström**, density in **g/cm³**, angles as the grazing angle **θ in degrees** (not 2θ). Wherever a wavelength is expected, a photon energy in eV is accepted instead and converted with $\lambda[\text{\AA}] = 12398.42 / E[\text{eV}]$; the wavelength actually used is echoed back.

Every tool that takes or returns a layered structure uses one JSON form, listed from the substrate to the surface:

```
{
  "substrate": {"material": "SiO2", "density": 2.2, "sigma": 3.0},
  "buffer":    {"material": "Ru", "thickness": 197.0, "sigma": 3.0},
  "stacks": [
    {"N": 30, "layers": [
      {"material": "Ru", "thickness": 14.7, "sigma": 3.0, "density": 12.4},
      {"material": "C", "thickness": 53.8, "sigma": 3.0, "density": 2.2}
    ]}
  ],
  "cap":      {"material": "Ru", "thickness": 20.0, "sigma": 3.0}
}
```

- `material` is a Henke table name, matched case-insensitively (`list_materials` gives the valid names).
- `density` is optional and defaults to the bulk value from the table; the value used is echoed.
- `buffer` (between substrate and first stack) and `cap` (on top) are optional. Several stacks are allowed.
- Numeric results are rounded to 6 significant digits.

Reference Tools

TOOL	DESCRIPTION
<code>describe_server</code>	Call it first. Reports the server version and git revision, the Henke directory, the unit conventions, the material-name syntax, the structure form, the limits, the working-directory layout, and a summary of every tool.
<code>list_materials</code>	The Henke tables the server can use, optionally filtered by an element pool. Each entry gives the table name, formula, bulk density and atomic mass.
<code>optical_constants</code>	δ and β of $n = 1 - \delta + i\beta$ for one material at one wavelength or energy, plus n , k and the nearby absorption edges. Unknown materials are refused with <code>unknown_material</code> .
<code>list_templates</code>	The multilayer design templates (one period each: sub-layers with thickness rule, σ , density, capping variants) that <code>optimize_mirror</code> can start from, optionally filtered by a material pool.

Calculation Tools

TOOL	DESCRIPTION
<code>calc_reflectivity</code>	Specular reflectivity of a structure over a θ range at one wavelength: <code>theta_min</code> , <code>theta_max</code> , <code>points</code> , <code>polarization</code> (<code>s</code> , <code>p</code> , <code>sp</code>) and an optional beam divergence <code>delta_theta</code> . Returns the curve inline when short enough and always as <code>jobs\<id>\curve.dat</code> , the Bragg peaks (order, θ_B , R_{peak} , FWHM) and the critical angle. This is the GUI's curve for the same structure (see Calculation).
<code>evaluate_lines</code>	Scores a structure against a set of X-ray emission lines (<code>name</code> , <code>lambda</code> or <code>energy</code> , <code>weight</code>) with the universal optimizer's own figure of merit; optional <code>fitness</code> overrides. The number is directly comparable with what <code>optimize_mirror</code> reports (see Universal Mirror > Figure of Merit).

Optimisation and Jobs

Two tools take longer than a request should wait for. They return a `job_id` at once and run in a background thread; the client polls.

TOOL	DESCRIPTION
<code>optimize_mirror</code>	Searches for the periodic multilayer that best serves a set of emission lines with the XRFCalc particle swarm. Takes the optimizer configuration (lines, <code>element_pool</code> , excluded pairs, structure ranges, fitness, optimizer settings, substrate, template), a <code>seed</code> and <code>top_k</code> (default 5). The result holds the <code>top_k</code> distinct structures with genome, figure of merit, per-line results and the <code>.xrfx</code> package written for each.
<code>job_status</code>	State of a job without waiting: <code>queued</code> , <code>running</code> , <code>finished</code> , <code>failed</code> , <code>cancelled</code> or <code>unknown</code> , with the current iteration and budget, the best value so far, elapsed seconds and the last message.
<code>job_result</code>	The result of a finished job. Fails with <code>job_not_finished</code> while it runs, <code>job_failed</code> when it ended in an error, <code>job_cancelled</code> when it was stopped.
<code>cancel_job</code>	Asks a job to stop and returns its state. A running job usually stops within a second or two; poll <code>job_status</code> to see it become <code>cancelled</code> .

Determinism and lifetime: With the same `seed` and inputs, `optimize_mirror` and `fit_xrr` give identical results; the seed used is echoed. Jobs do not survive the server: if the process ends, running jobs are lost and `job_status` reports `unknown` after a restart. Each job's folder `jobs\<job_id>` keeps its request, progress log and outputs.

Fitting

TOOL	DESCRIPTION
<code>fit_xrr</code>	Fits a layer model to a measured curve with the GUI's LFPSO, minimising the same χ^2 X-Ray Calc 3 displays (see Fitting). Returns a <code>job_id</code> ; the result is read with <code>job_result</code> .

The main arguments:

ARGUMENT	MEANING
<code>measurement_id</code> or <code>curve</code>	The measured data: an inbox id such as <code>"RuC-07/xrr.dat"</code> , or the curve inline.
<code>structure</code>	The start model in the structure JSON.
<code>free</code>	Which values may vary. Each entry addresses one layer by its <code>stack</code> index (from the substrate up, or <code>"cap"</code> / <code>"buffer"</code>) and <code>layer</code> index, and lists the <code>parameters</code> that take part: <code>"thickness"</code> , <code>"sigma"</code> , <code>"density"</code> . An entry <code>{"target": "period", "stack": k}</code> frees the period of repeating stack <i>k</i> instead; at least one thickness of that stack must be free too. Scale, background and resolution are not fitted; asking for them is answered with <code>not_fittable</code> .
<code>bounds</code>	One <code>min</code> / <code>max</code> pair per free parameter (<code>stack</code> , <code>layer</code> , <code>parameter</code>), or per free period (<code>target: "period"</code>). Omitted bounds default to the start value $\pm 30\%$; the start value must lie inside the range. Every fitted value stays inside its bounds, and the result's <code>bounds_used</code> lists the ranges that applied.
<code>lambda</code> or <code>energy</code> , <code>theta_range</code>	The wavelength (or photon energy) of the measurement and the θ interval to fit.
<code>scale</code>	A fixed multiplier applied to the measured intensities before the fit (the manual's Normalize step), default 1. Not fitted.
<code>smooth</code>	<code>{"passes": n}</code> , 0 to 10, runs the GUI's Data > Smooth on the measured curve before the fit. Order: scale, then smooth, then the <code>theta_range</code> trim, as in Data Conditioning .
<code>optimizer</code>	<code>population</code> (default 500), <code>iterations</code> (default 100), tolerance. The result carries <code>optimizer_used</code> with every default filled in.
<code>profile</code> , <code>seed</code>	Allow per-period thickness polynomials (the GUI's polynomial mode), and the random seed.
<code>polarization</code> , <code>resolution</code> , <code>chi2</code> , <code>r_min</code>	Polarization (<code>s</code> , <code>p</code> , <code>sp</code>), the instrumental resolution width, the χ^2 weighting options of the GUI's fit dialog, and the reflectivity floor below which points are ignored.

The result holds the fitted structure (with the expanded per-period profile when `profile` was set), χ^2 , the scale, background and resolution values, the start model, the measured, calculated and residual curves as files under the job folder, and the path of the `fit.xrcx` written for the fit. Open that file in the GUI to check the fit yourself.

Inbox: Measured Curves

Measured curves reach the server through the `inbox\` folder, one subfolder per specimen. You copy the files there; the server only reads them and never modifies them.

TOOL	DESCRIPTION
<code>list_measurements</code>	Every file in the inbox, optionally filtered by specimen, with its id " <code><specimen>/<file></code> ", size, SHA-256, modified time, and the specimen's metadata file if present.
<code>get_measurement</code>	One curve as $[\theta, \text{intensity}]$ pairs, parsed the way the GUI parses a data file (see File Formats): two columns separated by tab or space, comma accepted as the decimal mark, non-numeric lines reported as the header. <code>max_points</code> decimates a long curve for inline return; the file stays raw.

Projects

TOOL	DESCRIPTION
<code>save_project</code>	Writes <code>projects\<name>.xrcx</code> that opens in the GUI with no conversion: the structure as the active model, the calculated curve beside it, and optionally a measured curve (an inbox id or a job's curves via <code>curves.job_id</code>). A project saved from a fit job carries the job's own fit settings, so it opens as the fit that ran. Refuses to overwrite unless <code>overwrite: true</code> .
<code>load_project</code>	Reads a project back: the active model's structure in the structure JSON, its profile extensions, the calculation parameters (angles always as θ), and a summary of the embedded curves.
<code>list_projects</code>	The <code>.xrcx</code> files in <code>projects\</code> with size, SHA-256 and modified time. Nothing is written.

Example Session

A typical exchange, with the assistant's tool calls in order. The curve `RuC-07\xrr.dat` was copied into the inbox beforehand.

1. `describe_server` — confirm the revision and the Henke directory.
2. `list_measurements` → finds `"RuC-07/xrr.dat"`; `get_measurement` with `max_points: 200` to look at the curve.
3. `calc_reflectivity` with the nominal Ru/C structure (30 periods, $d = 68.5 \text{ \AA}$) at $\lambda = 1.5406 \text{ \AA}$ — compare the Bragg peak position with the measurement.
4. `fit_xrr` with the period of stack 0 and both layer thicknesses free, `smooth: {"passes": 1}`, `theta_range: [0.3, 4.0]`, `seed: 1` → `job_id: "fit-000003"`.
5. `job_status` every few seconds until `finished` (about 25 s for a 1000-point curve with the default population of 500).
6. `job_result` → fitted d , Γ , χ^2 , and the path of `fit.xrcx`.
7. `save_project` with `name: "RuC-07-fit"` and `curves.job_id: "fit-000003"` → `projects\RuC-07-fit.xrcx`, which you open in X-Ray Calc 3 to inspect and refit.

Practice: The lab's rule of thumb for the LFPSO is 100 iterations with 500 to 1000 particles: population wins over iterations. These are the server's defaults, so a request that names neither reproduces the GUI's usual fit.

Security

- **Sandbox:** the server can only read and write under its working directory. A path outside it is refused, never remapped.
- **Read-only inbox:** no tool has a write path into `inbox\` ; your measured data cannot be altered by an assistant.
- **No network:** the server speaks only over its own stdin and stdout to the client that started it. It opens no ports.
- **Journal:** every call and result is appended to `log\calls.json1` ; the file is never truncated by the server.
- **Structured errors:** failures are returned as `{code, message, detail}` . The process never shows a dialog or waits for a key, so it is safe to run unattended.

Smoke Test

The repository ships an end-to-end check, `XRC_MCP\smoke\session.ps1` . It starts the server in a throwaway working directory, calls every one of the 16 tools over one live stdio session (jobs are submitted, polled and read; one is cancelled), and checks the Ru/C Bragg-peak angle, seed determinism of the optimizer and the fit, the `path_outside_workdir` refusal, that the inbox is byte-identical afterwards, and that the journal holds exactly one line per call.

```
pwsh -File XRC_MCP\smoke\session.ps1
```

Exit code 0 means every check passed; `-KeepWorkdir` leaves the work directories behind for inspection. It takes a few seconds.

See Also

- [Fitting \(Optimization\)](#) — the LFPSO the server runs
- [Universal Mirror Optimizer](#) — the optimizer behind `optimize_mirror`
- [File Formats](#) — `.xrcx` and data files
- [Source Code & Git](#) — building the server

18 File Formats

Project files (.xrcx), experimental data files, Henke tables, and the settings file

Project File (.xrcx)

A ZIP archive containing:

- `project.dsc` — project metadata (title, descriptions)
- `params.dsc` — complete model definitions in text format (layers, stacks, parameters, calculation settings)
- Embedded experimental data files

Experimental Data Files

Plain text, two columns separated by tabs or spaces:

```
# Optional comment lines starting with #
0.100    1.000000
0.200    0.999850
...
```

Column 1: Angle (degrees) or wavelength (Angstroms)

Column 2: Reflectivity (typically 0 to 1)

Henke Tables

Binary or text files in the `Henke/` directory containing wavelength-dependent atomic form factors (f_1 , f_2) for each element. These files are required for reflectivity calculations and are included with the application.

Settings File (xrc3.ini)

Standard Windows INI file format. Sections include:

- `[Path]` — directory paths
- `[Window]` — window position and size
- `[Options]` — behavior flags
- `[Graphics]` — chart display settings
- `[Calc]` — calculation settings

See Also

- [Projects](#)
- [Experimental Data](#)
- [Application Settings](#)

19 Illustrative Examples

Single-layer coatings, periodic mirrors, polynomial fitting, and a supermirror

The following examples from the literature demonstrate the application of XRC3 to different types of structures (Penkov *et al.*, 2024).

Single-Layer Coating

Evaluation of a single-layer TiZrNi coating deposited by DC magnetron sputtering. The XRR was fitted starting with a two-layer model (TiZrNi + TiO₂), which yielded a cost function of ~0.48. Adding extra layers minimized the cost function to 0.14, revealing non-stoichiometric surface layers and hydrocarbon contamination.

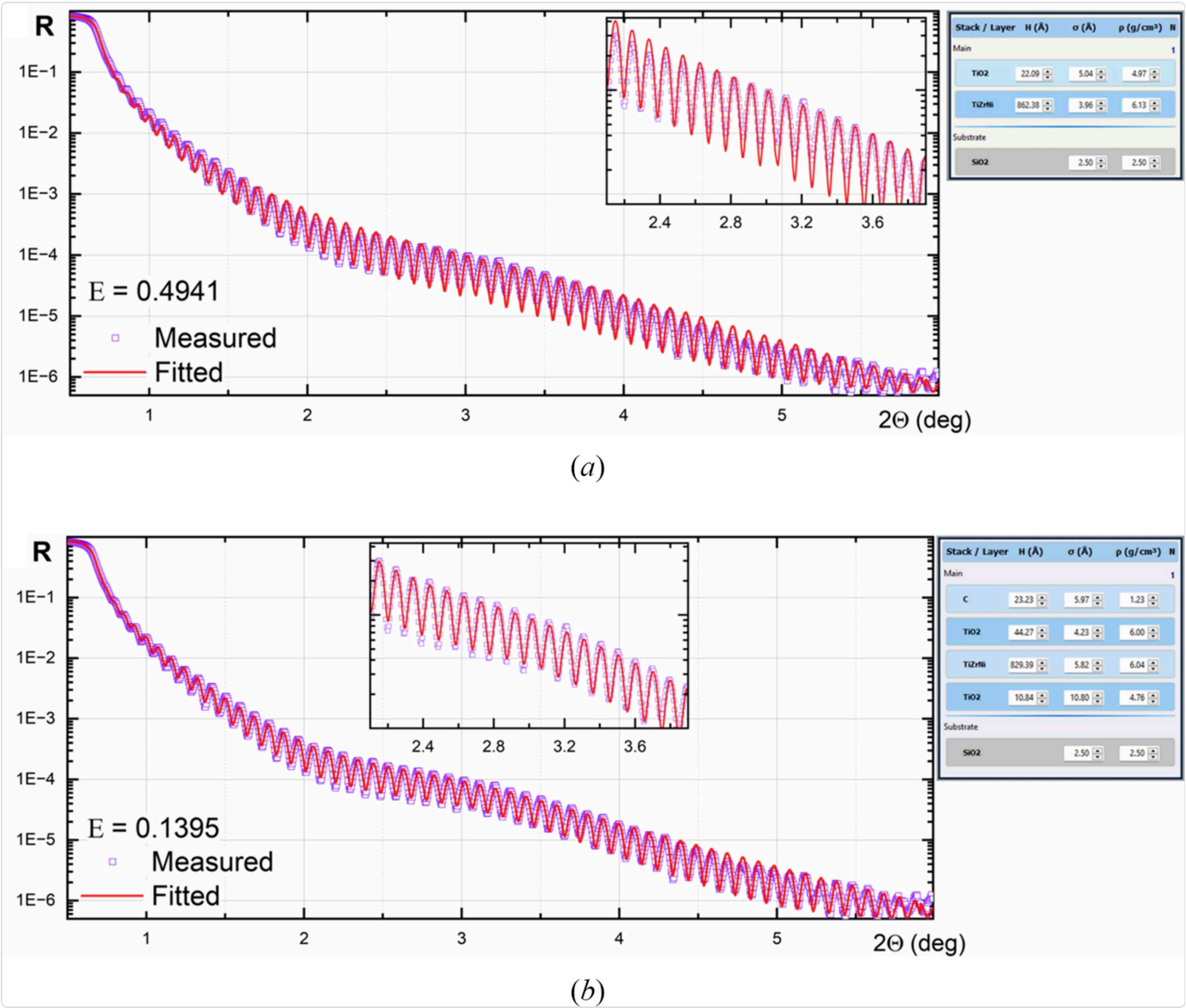


Figure 5. XRR curve fitting for a single-layer coating. (a) Two-layer model. (b) Four-layer model. Insets show the fitted structures. (From Penkov *et al.*, 2024.)

Periodic X-Ray Mirrors

Fitting of XRR curves for Mo/Si and Mo/B periodic multilayer mirrors (PMMs) in periodic mode. The Mo/Si results reveal the well-known asymmetric intermixed zones between Mo and Si. For the 2.3 nm period Mo/B PMM, fitting revealed thin asymmetric intermixing zones and a density difference between the thick Mo sublayer (near-bulk density) and the 0.6 nm Mo layers within the periodic structure (84% of bulk).

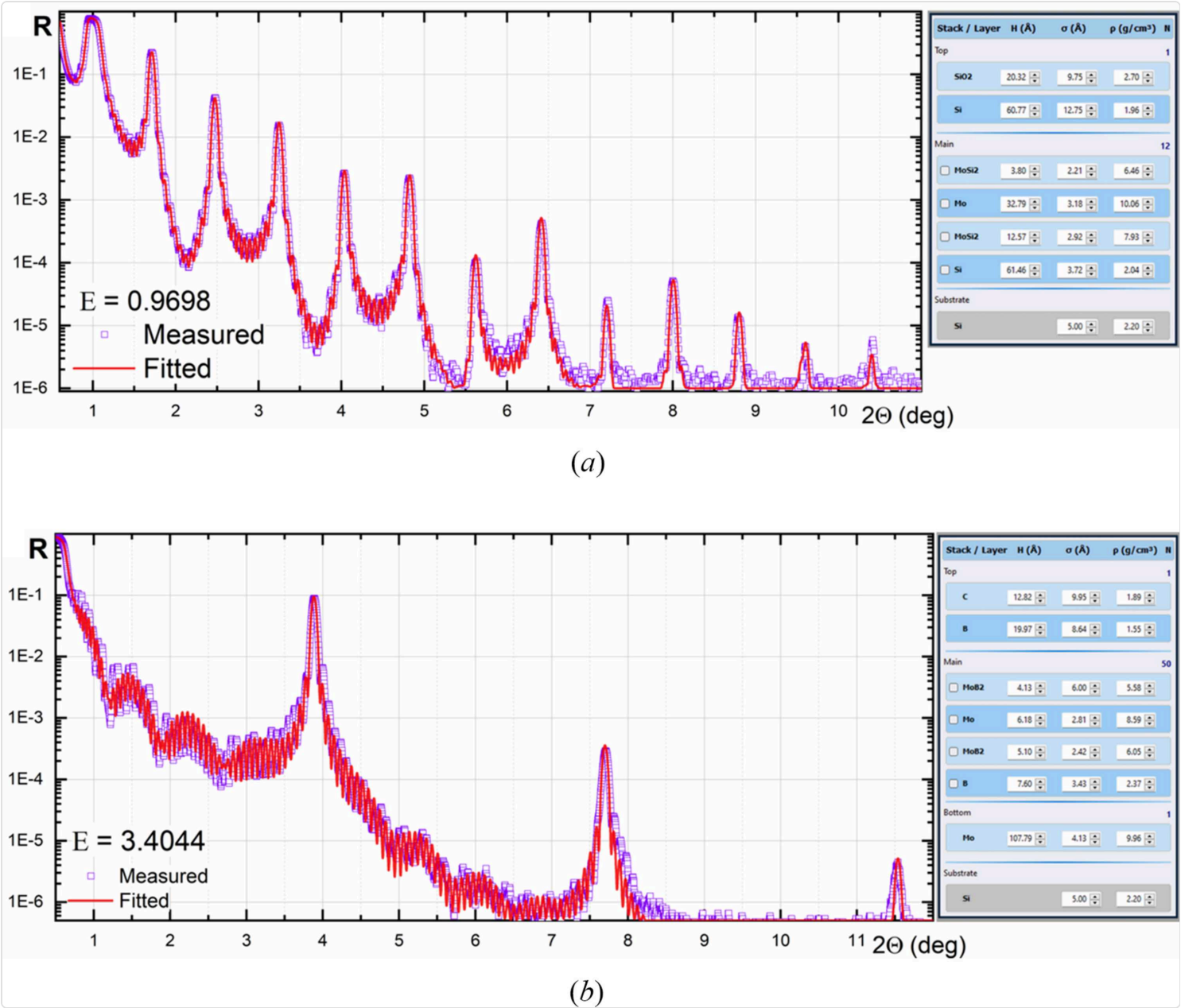


Figure 6. XRR curve fitting for X-ray mirrors. (a) Mo/Si. (b) Mo/B. (From Penkov et al., 2024.)

Polynomial Fitting on Graded PMMs

A W/BN PMM fitted in polynomial mode. The broadening and shape changes of diffraction peaks indicate variation of layer parameters across the stack. Due to unstable deposition conditions, the thickness and roughness of layers were found to vary gradually.

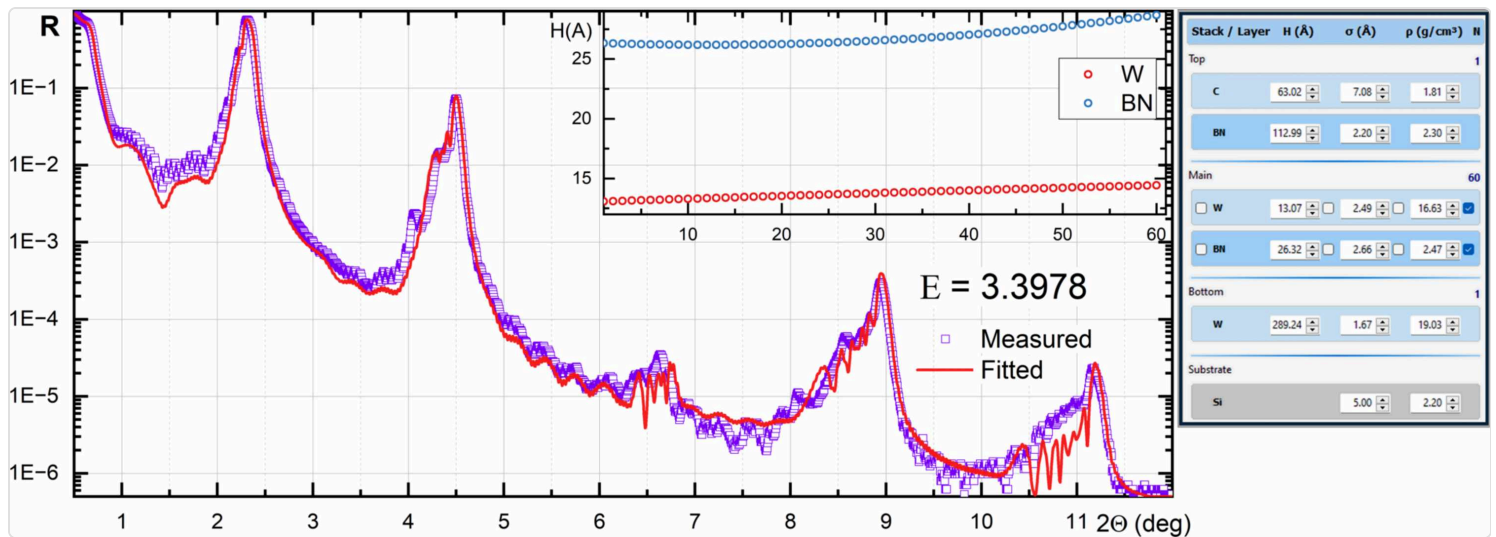


Figure 7. Polynomial XRR curve fitting for a W/BN X-ray mirror with gradually changed thickness of layers. (From Penkov et al., 2024.)

Supermirror

An Sb/B₄C supermirror fitted in irregular mode with paired roughness and density. The fitting revealed the designed depth-graded structure.

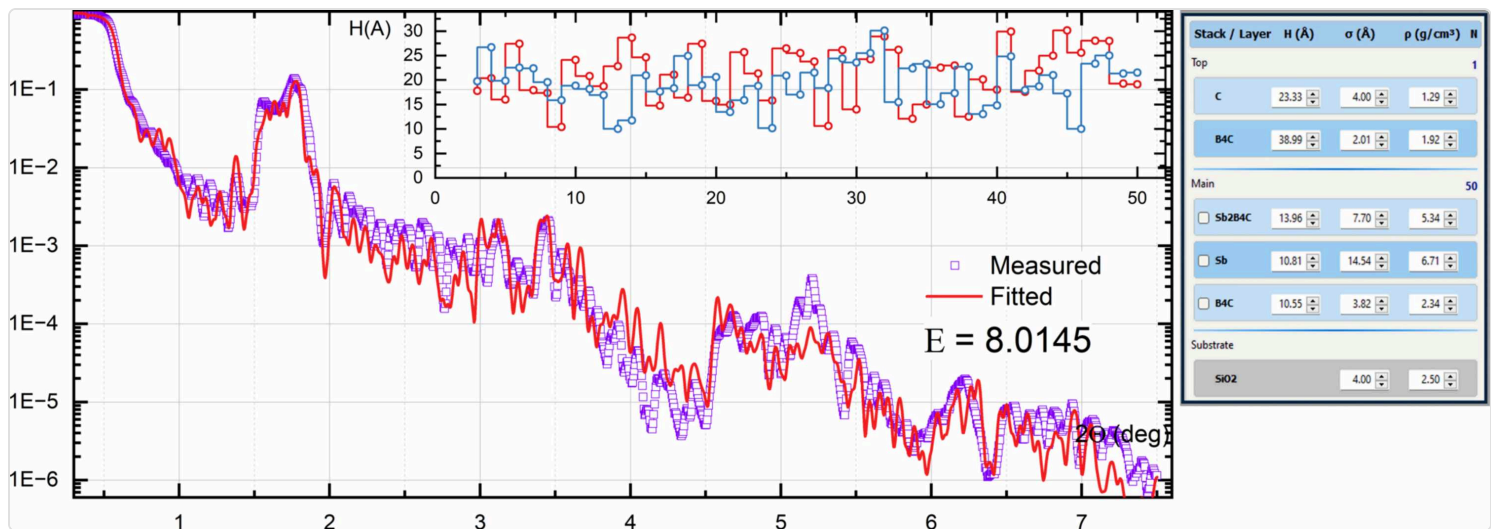


Figure 8. XRR curve fitting for an Sb/B₄C supermirror. (From Penkov et al., 2024.)

See Also

- [Fitting \(Optimization\)](#)
- [Quick Start](#)

20 Troubleshooting

Crashes, x32 versus x64, locked projects, convergence, slow calculation, data import

Application crashes without error message

This is typically caused by running out of memory when solving very large fitting problems (many layers or a very large population size).

Solution: Use the **x64 version** (`XRayCalc3.x64.exe`). It is somewhat slower than the x32 version for small models, but can address much larger amounts of RAM. The x32 version is limited to approximately 2 GB of memory.

Choosing between x32 and x64

Both versions are included in the distribution:

VERSION	ADVANTAGE	LIMITATION
x32 (<code>XRayCalc3.exe</code>)	~2× faster calculation	Limited to ~2 GB RAM
x64 (<code>XRayCalc3.x64.exe</code>)	Handles large models and populations	Slower for small models

Use **x32** for routine calculations with small-to-medium models. Switch to **x64** when working with large multilayer structures, high population sizes, or when you encounter crashes.

The application shows a “project locked” message

Another instance of X-Ray Calc 3 may have the project open, or a previous session crashed without releasing the lock. Close the other instance, or manually delete the `temp.lock` file from the temp directory (`%TEMP%\X-RayCalc3\`).

Fitting does not converge

- **Widen the fit limits** — the initial parameter bounds may be too narrow to contain the true solution.
- **Increase population size** — more particles explore the parameter space more thoroughly.
- **Increase iterations** — the algorithm may need more time to converge.
- **Enable Shake** — this helps escape local minima.
- **Check initial model** — a better starting guess leads to faster convergence.
- **Try a different fitting mode** — Periodic mode may work better than Irregular for regular multilayers, and vice versa.

Calculation is slow

- Ensure multi-threading is enabled (**Settings** > **Calc & Fit** > **Auto (Use all)**).
- Reduce the number of calculation points (N) for preliminary calculations.
- Use the **x32 version** for small-to-medium models — it is approximately 2× faster than x64.
- Use the **x64 version** only when the model is too large for x32 (memory limit).

Material not found

- Check the spelling (chemical formula must be exact, e.g., "SiO2" not "Sio2").
- The material may not exist in the Henke database. Use **Tools** > **Create New Material** to add it.

Chart appears empty after calculation

- Check that the angle/wavelength range is appropriate for the structure.
- For very thin films, use small angles (0.01 to 5 degrees).
- Switch between linear and logarithmic scale — the reflectivity may be visible only on one scale.
- Verify that the model has at least one layer defined.

Data import fails

- Ensure the data file is plain text with two numeric columns.
- Remove any header lines that are not prefixed with `#`.
- Check that decimal separators match your system locale (period vs. comma).
- Try pasting the data via clipboard instead.

See Also

- [Installation & First Launch](#)
- [Fitting \(Optimization\)](#)
- [Online Wiki](#)

21 Source Code & Git

The GitHub repository: getting the source, branches, building, dependencies, tests, and contributing

The Repository

X-Ray Calc 3 is open source. The complete source code, the issue tracker, the release installers and the [wiki](#) live in one Git repository on GitHub:

```
https://github.com/OleksiyPenkov/X-RayCalc3
```

The repository holds more than the GUI. It is a Delphi project group with four programs that share one calculation engine:

PROGRAM	PURPOSE
XRayCalc3	The GUI application this manual describes (<code>XRayCalc3.exe</code> , <code>XRayCalc3.x64.exe</code>).
xrccmd	Command-line calculation, fitting, and the Universal Mirror Optimizer .
XRFCalc	GUI for viewing and running universal-mirror optimizations (<code>.xrfx</code> result files).
XRC_MCP	The MCP server that exposes the engine to AI assistants.

Releases: You do not need the source to use the program. Windows installers are published under **Releases** on the repository page; each installer ships the 32-bit and 64-bit GUI, the Henke optical-constant tables and the example projects.

Getting the Source

Install **Git for Windows**, then clone the repository:

```
git clone https://github.com/OleksiyPenkov/X-RayCalc3.git
cd X-RayCalc3
```

To update a clone you already have:

```
git pull
```

If you only want to read the code, the **Code > Download ZIP** button on GitHub gives you a snapshot of the current branch without Git.

Branches and History

REF	CONTENT
<code>master</code>	The development branch since 2023. Releases are built from it. This is what <code>git clone</code> checks out.
<code>main</code>	The earlier public history with the flat directory layout and the 3.5.x releases, kept for reference.
tag <code>legacy-main-3.5.3</code>	The last state of that earlier history.

Commit messages follow a small convention: a leading `+` marks a new feature, a leading `*` a modification or fix. `git log --oneline` is therefore a readable change list.

Repository Layout

<code>XRayCalc3/</code>	GUI application
<code>Forms/</code>	Main windows (<code>frm_Main</code> , <code>settings</code> , <code>about</code> , ...)
<code>Views/</code>	Reusable frames (<code>chart info</code> , <code>project panel</code> , ...)
<code>Units/</code>	Business logic (<code>config</code> , <code>types</code> , <code>helpers</code> , <code>orchestrators</code>)
<code>LFPSO/</code>	Particle swarm optimization for curve fitting
<code>Components/</code>	Custom VCL components + package (<code>tree</code> , <code>grid</code> , <code>editors</code>)
<code>Editors/</code>	Data editor dialogs (<code>profile</code> , <code>Henke table</code> , <code>JSON</code> , ...)
<code>Assets/</code>	Icons, this help, development plans
<code>Tests/</code>	DUnitX test suite
<code>XRC_CMD/</code>	<code>xrccmd</code> , the command-line interface
<code>XRFCalc/</code>	XRF mirror-design GUI
<code>XRC_MCP/</code>	MCP server for AI assistants
<code>Shared/</code>	
<code>Math/</code>	Calculation engine, complex math, materials database
<code>Universal/</code>	Universal-mirror types, fitness, templates, XRF lines
<code>_Out/</code>	Build output (<code>BIN/</code> , <code>DCU/</code> , <code>DCU64/</code>)
<code>_Installer/</code>	Inno Setup script and deployment script
<code>docs/</code>	Design documents and implementation plans
<code>XRC3.groupproj</code>	Delphi project group

Project files are `.xrcx` archives (see [File Formats](#)). Lengths are in ångström, densities in g/cm³, angles are the grazing angle θ in degrees, throughout the code.

Building

The programs are written in Delphi (Object Pascal) and build with **Embarcadero RAD Studio 37.0** (Delphi 13). Win32 is the primary target for the GUI and the CLI; XRC_MCP is built for Win64 only.

In the IDE

1. Open `XRC3.groupproj` in RAD Studio.

2. Choose the **Release** configuration and the **Win32** platform (or Win64 for the 64-bit GUI).
3. Right-click the project group in the Project Manager and select **Build All**. The build order is XRayCalc3 → XRayCalcVisualControls → xrccmd → XRFCalc → XRC_MCP.

From the command line

Set the Embarcadero environment variables, then call MSBuild for the project you need. Always use `/t:Build`; `/t:Make` does not work with these projects.

```
set BDS=C:\Program Files (x86)\Embarcadero\Studio\37.0
set BDSCOMMONDIR=C:\Users\Public\Documents\Embarcadero\Studio\37.0
set MSB=C:\Windows\Microsoft.NET\Framework\v4.0.30319\msbuild.exe

%MSB% XRayCalc3\XRayCalc3.dproj /t:Build /p:Config=Release /p:Platform=Win32
%MSB% XRC_CMD\xrccmd.dproj      /t:Build /p:Config=Release /p:Platform=Win32
%MSB% XRFCalc\XRFCalc.dproj     /t:Build /p:Config=Release /p:Platform=Win32
%MSB% XRC_MCP\XRC_MCP.dproj     /t:Build /p:Config=Release /p:Platform=Win64
```

Executables land in `_Out\BIN\`. The 64-bit GUI is `XRayCalc3.x64.exe`; `XRayCalc3.exe` is the 32-bit build.

Git on PATH: XRC_MCP regenerates `XRC_MCP\units\gitrev.inc` from `git describe --always --dirty` in its pre-build event, so `git` must be on `PATH` when you build it. The value is what the server reports as its revision; a `-dirty` suffix means the tree had uncommitted changes when it was built.

Dependencies

The following libraries must be on the Delphi library path for the platform you build:

LIBRARY	USED FOR
OmniThreadLibrary 3.08 or later	Parallel calculation and fitting. Older versions truncate 64-bit code pointers in <code>OtlTaskControl.pas</code> , and every Win64 build that runs the optimizer or the fit then hangs at the first iteration. github.com/gabr42/OmniThreadLibrary
FastMath	Vectorised math. github.com/neslib/FastMath
Raize Components (Konopka Signature VCL Controls)	UI controls (<code>Rz*</code> prefix).
Virtual TreeView	Project tree and grids.
Abbrevia	The <code>.xrcx</code> ZIP archives.
SynEdit	The JSON and text editors.
DUnitX	The test suite; shipped with RAD Studio.

Symptom of an old OmniThreadLibrary: a Win64 fit or optimization that stops at iteration 0 and a process that will not exit. Win32 builds are unaffected. Check out the library at tag `release-3.08` or later and rebuild.

Running the Tests

`XRayCalc3\Tests\XRayCalc3Tests.dproj` is a DUnitX suite (Win32, Debug) covering the calculation engine, the Henke tables, the LPSO fit, the universal optimizer and every XRC_MCP unit. Build it, then run:

```
%MSB% XRayCalc3\Tests\XRayCalc3Tests.dproj /t:Build /p:Config=Debug
XRayCalc3\Tests\_Out\BIN\XRayCalc3Tests.exe --exitbehavior:Continue
```

The XRC_MCP server additionally has an end-to-end smoke test, described in [MCP Server > Smoke Test](#).

Contributing

- **Bug reports and feature requests** go to the **Issues** tab of the repository. Attach the project file (`.xrcx`) and the measured data that reproduce the problem, and state whether you ran the 32-bit or the 64-bit build (see [Troubleshooting](#)).
- **Code changes** are welcome as pull requests against `master` . Fork the repository on GitHub, create a branch, commit with the `+ / *` prefix convention, and open the pull request. Build the Win32 Release target and run the test suite before submitting.
- **Documentation** changes to this manual are code changes too: the pages live in `XRayCalc3/Assets/Docs/Help/` . Tutorial-style material belongs in the [wiki](#), which anyone with a GitHub account can edit.

Licence and Citation

X-Ray Calc 3 is distributed under the **GNU General Public License v3.0**; see the `LICENSE` file in the repository.

If you use the software in published work, please cite:

- Penkov, O. V., Li, M., Mikki, S., Devizenko, A. & Kopylets, I. (2024). *X-Ray Calc 3: improved software for simulation and inverse problem solving for X-ray reflectivity*. J. Appl. Cryst. **57**, 555–566. doi:10.1107/S1600576724001031
- Penkov, O. V., Kopylets, I. A., Khadem, M. & Qin, T. (2020). *X-Ray Calc: a software for the simulation of X-ray reflectivity*. SoftwareX **12**, 100528. doi:10.1016/j.softx.2020.100528

See Also

- [Online Wiki](#) — tutorials and notes hosted next to the repository
- [MCP Server](#) — the fourth program in the project group
- [Introduction](#) — what the software does

22 Online Wiki

The GitHub wiki that accompanies this manual: its pages, and how to read and edit them

Overview

Besides this manual, which is installed with the program and describes every feature, X-Ray Calc 3 has an **online wiki** hosted with the source repository on GitHub:

```
https://github.com/OleksiyPenkov/X-RayCalc3/wiki
```

The wiki is the place for material that changes faster than a release, or that is easier to write as a walkthrough than as a reference: tutorials with screenshots, worked fitting sessions, benchmark results, and answers to questions that come up repeatedly. It is public, needs no login to read, and can be edited by anyone with a GitHub account.

Which one to read: Start with the wiki's **Getting started** if you are new to the program and want to see a complete session end to end. Use this manual when you need to know what a particular setting, button or file format does.

Wiki Pages

PAGE	CONTENT
Home	Entry page with links to every other page.
Getting started	A first session: open a demonstration project, run a calculation from the Computation tab, edit layers, stacks and model properties, change polarization and the angle range, and export or plot the result.
How to create a model and calculate XRR	Building a multilayer model from an empty project: stacks, layers, materials from the Henke database, and the calculation settings.
Working with experimental data	Loading a measured curve, the expected file format, and comparing it with the calculated one.
Working with experimental data (Data conditioning)	Preparing a measured curve for fitting: normalize, smooth and trim, in that order, with the reasoning behind each step.
Manual curve fitting	Fitting by hand before (or instead of) the automatic fit: create an initial model and load the data, roughly match the period of the structure, then adjust the roughness of the layers until the peak intensities agree.
Benchmarks	Convergence studies of the fitting algorithm: the effect of the algorithm constants, LFPSO versus Shake LFPSO on several structures, and how the iteration count and population size influence convergence, with CPU timings. A benchmark archive can be downloaded from the repository.
Troubleshooting	Known problems and their remedies, for example the application closing without an error message when a large fit runs out of memory in the 32-bit build.
User Manual	An older, interface-oriented description of the main menu and toolbars. Superseded by this manual, kept for readers of earlier versions.

This Manual and the Wiki

Several wiki pages have a counterpart here. The wiki version is the walkthrough; the chapter here is the reference.

WIKI PAGE	CHAPTER IN THIS MANUAL
Getting started	Quick Start
How to create a model and calculate XRR	Defining a Model, Calculation
Working with experimental data	Experimental Data, File Formats
Working with experimental data (Data conditioning)	Experimental Data > Data Conditioning Walkthrough
Manual curve fitting	No counterpart: the technique is described only in the wiki. Fitting covers the automatic fit.
Benchmarks	No counterpart. Tools > Benchmark describes how to run the built-in benchmark on your own machine.
Troubleshooting	Troubleshooting

Tip: The [Help > User Manual](#) menu command opens this manual in your browser. The wiki is at the address at the top of this page; the repository's README links to it as well.

Editing the Wiki

Corrections and new tutorials are welcome. GitHub wikis are edited in the browser:

1. Sign in to GitHub (a free account is enough).
2. Open the page you want to change and click **Edit** in the top right, or click **New page** on any wiki page to add one.
3. Write in Markdown: `#` headings, `*` bullets, `![caption](image-url)` for screenshots. The **Preview** tab shows the rendered result.
4. Enter a short edit summary and click **Save page**. The change is live at once.

Screenshots are added by dragging the image into the editor, which uploads it and inserts the Markdown link for you. Please keep to the existing page structure: one topic per page, a short introduction, then numbered steps.

What belongs where: Walkthroughs, tips, benchmark results and questions-and-answers go in the wiki. A description of what a setting does, a file format, or a keyboard shortcut belongs in this manual, which is versioned with the source code (see [Source Code & Git > Contributing](#)).

Cloning the Wiki

A GitHub wiki is itself a Git repository, so you can keep an offline copy, edit pages in your own editor, or back it up:

```
git clone https://github.com/OleksiyPenkov/X-RayCalc3.wiki.git
```

Each page is one Markdown file named after its title (`Getting-started.md` , `Manual-curve-fitting.md` , and so on). Commit and push to publish your edits; pushing requires write access to the wiki, which every signed-in GitHub user has unless the repository owner restricts it.

See Also

- [Source Code & Git](#) — the repository the wiki belongs to
- [Quick Start](#) — the manual's own tutorial
- [Troubleshooting](#)